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THE TEN COMMANDMENTS

SERMONS

PREACHED AT HOLY TRINITY, CHELSEA

BY

ROBERT EYTON

RECTOR OF UPPER CHELSEA, PREBENDARY OF ST PAUL'S
SUB-ALMONER TO HER MAJESTY THE QUEEN

LONDON

KEGAN PAUL, TRENCH, TRÜBNER & CO. LTD.

1894



TO
MY COLLEAGUES
AT
HOLY TRINITY, UPPER CHELSEA,
WITH
MUCH AFFECTION AND DEEP GRATITUDE
THIS VOLUME
IS
DEDICATED.

PREFACE.

IN publishing this Volume of Sermons on the Ten Commandments, I desire to say generally, how much I owe to Dr Dale's Sermons on the same subject.

R. E.

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SERMON I.

SECOND SUNDAY AFTER EPIPHANY, 1893.

“If thou wilt enter into life, keep the Commandments.”—ST MATTHEW xix. 17.

THE glow and the brightness of Christmas is still upon us. We have knelt with shepherds and worshipped with wise men ; we have seen the “glory of the only-begotten of the Father” in Mary’s child ; we know that He, Who has come among us, has made all things new, that He has given answers to questions asked and asked in vain by those who sat “in darkness and in the shadow of death.” We recognise perhaps more fully than ever the interval which separates that knowledge of the Father, which has come to us through the Son, from the old dim guesses, the blind obedience, the gropings in the dark, the search for God and all that it involved, which characterised the old dispensation. And yet in spite of all this tremendous advance, this wondrous change which He has brought, when we come to sit at Christ’s feet and He opens His mouth to tell us how we are to enter into life, He sends us back again to the old revelation of Sinai for our first principles. True He fills them full of a meaning

that was unperceived in them before. True, He robs their negative form of its seeming barrenness and dreariness by declaring them to be perfectly kept by the positive law of love ; but it is still to the Mosaic commandment that He sends us back for our first principles ; it is to what He Himself learnt in a Jewish home when “ He increased in wisdom and in favour with God ”—to what He learnt during the self-imposed limitations of His human childhood—to what He received from Mary’s lips and heard expounded by the Rabbis of the day. For His education would be a really religious one, imparted not only through sight and hearing, not only by the observance of ceremony and attendance at feasts, but also through careful, positive teaching. The Old Testament had set before every Jewish mother an ideal of motherhood formed on a continuous succession of noble Hebrew mothers. It was no idle boast that “the Jews from their swaddling clothes were trained to see God as their Father and as the Maker of the world.” One cannot forbear to say in passing—would that every Christian child had advantages and opportunities like theirs ! A modern writer has criticised with much force and too much justice the defects of our English home education on its religious side, in its failure to present an ideal. * “Look,” says the author of “Natural Religion,” “Look how the

* Page 128.

English people treat their children. Try and discover from the way they train them, from the education they give them, what they wish them to be. They have ceased to have any ideal at all. Traces may be observed of an old ideal not quite forgotten, here and there a vague notion of instilling hardihood, a really decided wish to teach frankness and honesty and in a large class also good manners; but these are after all negative virtues. What do they wish their children to aim at? Except that when they grow up they are to make or have a livelihood and to take a satisfactory position in society and in the meanwhile that it would be hard for them not to enjoy themselves heartily, most parents would be puzzled to say what they wish for their children. And whatever they wish they wish so languidly that they entrust the realisation of it almost entirely to strangers, being themselves so they say—and indeed the Philistine or irreligious person always is—much engaged. The parent from sheer embarrassment or want of an ideal has in a manner abdicated, and it has become necessary to set apart a special class for the cultivation of parental feelings and duties. The modern school-master should change his name, for he has become a kind of standing or professional parent."

The need of an ideal, or definite moral standard so powerfully described here would not be felt by those who were charged with the education of Christ.

The ideal set before the Jewish child, based as it was on the Ten Commandments, was distinct enough ; while the atmosphere that surrounded him was distinctly religious. The God of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, the God of Israel, the God of the promises claimed him from the first, and his blessings and responsibilities were freely set before him. Of Jewish training it was no idle boast that "they were taught in the law from their earliest youth, that they bore in their souls the image of the Ten Commandments so that they were engraven on their soul." While the earliest religious teaching would come from the mother, it was the father who was bound to teach his son the commandments as if he had received them himself on Mount Sinai. At thirteen when the child was of age he became what was called a son of the Commandment or the Torah. But as a matter of fact the legal age was often anticipated in this respect by a year or more, and so it was that Christ went to Jerusalem on the first Pascha after He had reached His twelfth year. It is then that we find Him impressed with the consciousness that He "must be about His Father's business"—a consciousness which witnesses to the carefulness of His instruction and to the depth of His own meditation on the hidden meaning of the law. His whole subsequent teaching is based upon the eternal principles which underlie the old law. His own method is the outcome of the way in which He took

in the best results of His education. That method is to extricate the principles which underlie any of the Commandments with which He may be dealing. So He intercepts murder at the stage of anger, and adultery at the stage of lust, and false witness at the stage of inward hostility. His aim was to substitute principle for precept, spirit for letter and disposition for action.

This is briefly stated the kind of attitude which Christ appears to maintain and observe towards the Ten Commandments. At one time He explains their inward meaning, at another He resolves the ten into the two statements of the great law of love ; or again He bids us if we would "enter into life, keep the Commandments." But His attitude towards them is always one of reverence inasmuch as He recognised the eternal principles which underlay them. His attitude is very different from that which He assumed towards the oral law or towards the prohibitions of the Mishnah. The whole moral teaching of the Gospel possesses at once novelty and antiquity. On the one hand it possesses novelty, so far as it deduces results from principles—results which from the nature of the case could not have been anticipated. On the other hand it possesses antiquity, inasmuch as every idea of morals or religion which is stated therein may be traced back to its germ in the older Scriptures.

And this consideration helps us to see the right

position of the Ten Commandments in our Christian system. They contain and assert the germ thoughts out of which Christian morality grows ; they are not the full expression of Christian duty towards God or towards others, but they are the germ thoughts which implicitly contain that full expression. They cannot and ought not to be quoted or taught as, in their letter, expressing any thing final, but they have assumed their right place when they become laws for the heart—when we ask God to “incline our hearts to keep this law.” It is this conception of them as germ thoughts which I purpose to keep before you in my endeavour to make them practical and living to you. Such a treatment relieves us at once from the difficulties attending the minute examination of mere details which have passed away (such as the keeping of the Sabbath), and brings out their permanent force and meaning. It helps us to see how, in spite of their negative form, they yet reveal the Character and the Will of God, only they exhibit that Character and that Will not for the most part in its positive aspects (as Christ did), but as imposing certain primary restraints on a people living amid the vices of surrounding heathenism. When men stumble at their negative form, they should remember to whom they were given. A barbarous people—(such as the Israelites were at their exodus) with their religious thought degraded by idolatry, their moral sense corrupted by slavery

and tainted by the vices of their late masters, surrounded by nations who lived as they chose—could not bear strong meat. The first steps which were taken to raise them to a higher life must be by careful restriction, by an assertion of Monotheism, by safeguarding the reverence due to the One God, by ensuring that He should not be forgotten in the struggle for bare life ; and then by a careful prohibition of the worst of those vices which were freely indulged in by the nations around. First steps they were, and first steps only. To quote the letter of the Ten Commandments now, as though it were final in its demands, is to forget all this ; it is to be guilty of a grave misapplication which issues in false inferences. Their letter has undoubtedly ceased to apply to all who have learnt the law of love ; but they are not therefore obsolete. They contain the germ thoughts that lie at the root of all that is best and noblest in Christian conduct. Moreover, if we forget or ignore the law of love, we may need them still in their severe hardness, we may have to go back to their stern and rugged “Thou shalt not,” and let it begin its work of restraint within us—for any of us that work of restraint may again become the most absolute of necessities. But because we may have to go back to it, because we may find that we need to put ourselves under the stern discipline of “Thou shalt not,” and to remain there till we have learnt restraint, we must not think for a

moment that that prohibition represents God's full claim on ourselves. They are His first words for those who can bear nothing more ; His final words are "Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind," and "Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself."

The love of God and of man is a splendid and ennobling conception of a rule of life for those who can rise to it. "Love," it has been said, "and do what you like," for, if you love, you cannot do wrong. But it is only a law for those who can rise to it. And herein lies one of our greatest and most recurring puzzles and difficulties. The question will come to us sometimes, when we are brought face to face with the selfishness of luxury or the degradation of a money-getting life, 'Are we fit for Christianity?' 'Would not Judaism suit us better?' 'How is it that the law of love seems so often to fail and to break down in influencing conduct in a way and to an extent to which the old law of restraint and prohibition did not?' 'How is it that in our advice to individuals we are again and again driven back upon it?' We have to say, 'You must not go there, you must keep away from this or that person ; unless you do, all is over ; there is that born within you which must cause you to fall, unless you keep away.' A most interesting though painful study of psychology under the form of fiction has just raised this problem anew in some of our minds. The

difficulties attendant on the belief that the positive law of love of God and man are sufficient to regulate conduct in spite of environment or the influence of heredity, are there stated in the most powerful and almost bewildering fashion. There is drawn for us in the "Story of a Penitent Soul," a picture of one, trained under the ordinary emotional influences of modern Dissent, with its antinomian tendencies, face to face with a terrible temptation and haunted too by a hideous conviction that through taint in the blood he must fall ; and a graphic though painful picture is presented to us of the battlings and struggles of a stricken soul that has never realised (partly owing to the false pietism of its upbringing) that outward practice as well as inward feeling needs severe control, and that to argue that, because you are spiritual therefore you are safe anywhere, is a position full of danger. No doubt the difficulties described are partly incidental to the early training. The teaching that "doing is a deadly thing" still survives in its influence, and constitutes the great educational danger of Protestant Dissent. That danger is described by one of the leading Nonconformists in more severe terms than I can use. He is describing the attitude of the ordinary Antinomian. * "They seem to suppose that our external conduct is an outlying province over which God does not much care about exercising any strong control, that in claiming

* Dale on the "Ten Commandments," p. 14.

authority over the heart He has implicitly surrendered His authority over the outward life. The laws which affect our words and actions belong to the sphere of what they call mere morality, with which they have a secret feeling that spiritual men have no great concern. They forget that the nature of man is an organic unity." It is just here that the Ten Commandments touch us, because the nature of man is an organic unity. They remind us in a trenchant fashion that God must rule the outward action as well as the inward feeling; that because, as in the case before us, there is much that is good and beautiful that is mingled with sinful dispositions—because the veil between the highest sympathies which we can feel and the worst feelings, in which we can allow ourselves, is so slender, so easily broken through, so liable almost insensibly to melt away—we do need still the stern self-discipline of the "Thou shalt not" of the external rule of conduct which is emphasised in the Ten Commandments.

As long as this is obscured or forgotten, it is easy to persuade ourselves that we must sin, that it comes down to us in our blood, that it is part of our being, that circumstances are too hard; but with the law of Sinai—the great "Thou shalt not"—sounding in our ears, we are protected against what is really the deceitfulness of our self-love. After all we can keep away; we are masters of our conduct even if

the waywardness of our hearts entangles us and leads us astray.

While then we think of the Ten Commandments as only the germ thoughts of Christian morality, we must not let ourselves forget for one moment that they have their work to do for us still. Directly we feel disposed to consider ourselves beyond the need of their stern prohibitions because we are under the law of love, that work begins. God gave them to men to help them in their struggle with sin. God is still with us in the suffering entailed by "Thou shalt not" as much as in the blessedness implied in "Thou shalt love." God gave them to ensure that men should know that in that long and weary struggle of duty against inclination He was with them. In the sternness and the rigour of their prohibitions we feel the evidence of the Father's love—the Father Who fain would lavish His tenderness upon us, but Who sees that we may need the utmost rigour, the sharpest prohibition to hinder us from making shipwreck of our lives. They teach us still in their stern rigour that He cares not to make us happy now, but perfect for ever ; that He cares for the final result, that we should, through whatever trouble, be perfect and like unto Him. Nothing can satisfy Him but this ; nothing less than this can satisfy the longings of His heart ; and it is for this reason that we still pray as we listen to their stern prohibitions, "incline our hearts to keep this law."

SERMON II.

THIRD SUNDAY AFTER EPIPHANY, 1893.

“And God spake all these words, saying, I am the Lord thy God Which have brought thee out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of bondage. Thou shalt have no other gods before Me.”—EXODUS xx. 1, 2.

THE first and the greatest aim in the education of Israel is covered by this prohibition. The chosen nation, in order to do the work set before them, to fulfil their high destiny, must be monotheists. Their highest trust, their greatest privilege as well as their absolute qualification for the work before them was to have only one God.

I. This end is strictly kept in view in the first Commandment — they would become monotheists by owning no other God. No formal creed asserting the unity of God is put before them ; it is not said there is one God and none else ; nothing is said here of the claims of other gods ; there is no discussion raised or attempted to be raised about their existence or non-existence, for the simple reason that the people were not fit for anything of the kind. The Egyptians had their gods, the Moabites had their deities, the other heathen tribes had theirs, but

nothing is here said about them—no proof is attempted of their inferiority nor even any assertion made about them. The issue is clear, definite, unmistakable. To the only question which could be raised, Who is the one God? the answer is clear: “I Who brought thee out of the land of Egypt.” The incidents of that marvellous deliverance were too fresh in their minds for them to have any doubts as to Whom the Commandment meant. “I am the Lord thy God Which have brought thee out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of bondage. Thou shalt have no other gods before Me.” They knew Who God was from their recent contact with Him, they knew Who He was as they knew who Moses was—the personality of the One was as clear and vivid as that of the other. There was no possibility of confounding Him with the gods of the Egyptian pantheism—those deities of nature over whom He had trampled. They had seen the demonstration of Jehovah’s dominion over the forces of nature; they had seen in that demonstration a proof of the weakness of those other gods, they knew that “the gods of the heathen were but vanity,” but all that is only hinted at and then left: the monotheistic creed which was Israel’s great trust is to be built up “not by elaborate proof of the powerlessness of supposed rivals but by absolute prohibition of any dealings with any supposed rivals”: “Thou shalt have no other gods before Me.” Belief was to grow out of

practice. The Jewish nation demoralised by tyranny, corrupted by idolatry, were in no condition yet to appreciate the moral and intellectual bearings of monotheism, or to balance the claims of the forces of nature, or even to see through the senselessness of fetishism, they had to be trained by stern and vigorous prohibition—they must have no other gods but Jehovah. The truth must take its root in their national life before its overwhelming proportions could be intelligently recognised, or its inevitable consequences taken in, and that result could only be secured in one way: “I am the Lord thy God. Thou shalt have no other gods before Me.”

The subsequent history of Israel may be described as one long struggle on the part of all that was best and noblest and wisest in the Jewish nation to preserve this greatest trust. Long and weary was the struggle—for centuries the divided hearts and wayward wills of the people led them into every form of polytheism. It is almost ludicrous, if it were not so piteous, to read the histories of their childish backslidings. Any god whom another nation worshipped was the god for them. And this going after other gods began even in the desert. “The desert is monotheistic,” says M. Renan in one of his grandiose French phrases; but as a matter of fact their first sin there was to worship the calf; and after they had been living for years in the desert, they had to be punished for worshipping the gods of the Moabites.

Their whole history from beginning to end is stained with idolatry ; now it was the golden calves—now it was Astarte and the host of heaven—now it was deities in groves, on hills, and under every green tree, “the tabernacle of Moloch, the star of Remphan.” Their laws made stoning the penalty of idolatry, but laws had no power against the instincts of a people. All their great conditions, their apartness from other nations, their being a peculiar people, “God’s own people”—all that which might have appealed to their national pride and made them faithful to God—seemed to be in vain. Psalmist after Psalmist laments their backsliding in this matter—“they were a faithless and stubborn generation,” “a generation who cleaveth not steadfastly unto God.” “They believed not in God, and put not their trust in Him.” Only “when He slew them” was it that “they sought Him and turned to Him early” but even after all “they grieved Him with their hill altars and provoked Him to displeasure with their images,” “they turned their glory into the similitude of a calf that eateth hay,” “they joined themselves unto Baal-peor and ate the offerings of the dead.” Nay, “they worshipped idols which turned to their own decay.” So bewildered by Satan were they, so fascinated with the strange and weird cultus of Moloch that they lost the parental instinct, and that awful spectacle was seen of parents causing their own children to be cast into fire, deaf to their heart-rending and

supplicating cries—"they offered their sons and daughters unto devils and shed innocent blood, even blood which they offered unto the idols of Canaan." It was one long, piteous, heart-rending struggle. "Many a time did God deliver them, but they rebelled against Him with their own inventions," and the invention was always the same—a new god borrowed from some neighbouring nation. And through it all, like a man taming some wild animal, Jehovah bore with them. The pity, the long-suffering, the tenderness, the patience of God is nowhere more transparently revealed to us than in His dealing with Israel on this question. He is the true Father, Who sees that the one only thing that matters to His children is that they should own Him; and Who recks nothing of their affliction if only He can bring them to their true self; He is the Father Whose ear is ever open, Whose heart is ever yearning. And they are a stiff-necked generation all through the long struggle, only at last brought to reason and sense by two captivities—"they did always resist the Holy Ghost"—they always persecuted the prophets, and at last they were only brought by bitter suffering to acknowledge what they ought to have esteemed their highest trust and their deepest treasure—the knowledge of the One true God.

And there was no excuse of intellectual difficulty for them. They had not to think out the problem of abstract being. They knew Jehovah *by what He*

had done, by His great deliverance, by His repeated interference on their behalf. They had only to live in remembrance of that and all would be well, they would have "none other gods before Him." But all that instability, that mere childishness which so often characterises religious persons—and again, all the oppressive hopelessness which comes from trying to keep men straight who will want to go crooked—how it is all brought home to us, for our comfort and our learning of patience, in the Old Testament Scripture!

No one then, who reads the history of Israel, can doubt the practical value of this Commandment for them, both on account of its negative form and of its refusal to admit any question as to its terms. Imagine if they had had to think out the problem of an absolute Being; to evolve an idea of God and to say they believed in Him; to bow before a system of attributes. We see the wisdom, the Divineness of the command to be loyal to One Who not once, but always, delivered them—One Who was their Saviour in every struggle, their Leader, their own God. They had to be loyal to Him for the sake of mankind; because, if they were loyal, the highest morality as well as the noblest religious life would become possible for the world at large.

II. The historical interest of the gradual growth of Jewish monotheism must always be great, but has the story any practical value for us? Are we at

liberty merely to gaze on that long and interesting struggle as though it were a struggle for liberty of some oppressed nation like the Poles ; as though it were an experience into which we cannot enter, whose results we have only to enjoy? Has the First Commandment nothing to say to us? To us Astarte is a name, and the calf is a mere thing of stone. We have never seen an idol except perhaps in a museum, and then have only gazed in smiling contempt at the thought that any one could be so utterly silly as to worship a thing like that.

Yet we have our temptations to break the First Commandment as they had. It is often taught that the First Commandment forbids us Christians to love friends or money or position more than God. I doubt whether that is a true application of its inward meaning. To explain it thus involves the fallacy of a distributed middle, the use of the word "God" in two different senses.

No doubt there are idols still outside museums—idols within the heart—the idols of a money-loving, popularity-courting generation, — idols of social ambition, idols within the home as well as in the market-place. But these are not the gods which the First Commandment forbids us to worship, and it would not be a strict use of language to say that they' were. And yet the commandment, "Thou shalt have no other gods before Me," rings on in our ears.

There are still "gods many and lords many," and it is in the giving of our allegiance to these that we, like the Jews, break the First Commandment. The Jewish religion has been described as the negation of polytheism. Christianity is that also and something more too; but he would be a bold man who would say that the need of a negation of polytheism had passed away.

III. For to begin with, there is the god of the materialist—it is hard to call it a god, it is easier to call it an idol. Law, blind absolute, unheeding law is enthroned by him as god. A great hideous juggernaut grinds over a world of decay and death—a kingdom of matter and force is among us, of the origin of which we can give no more account than we can of its destiny. Under his reign sin, responsibility, conscience disappear; morality goes of course with them. Law is an inexorable tyrant; it reigns not only in the physical world, but in the sphere of moral action and purpose; not merely as influencing and as limiting our conduct, but as all powerful and as absolutely determining man's will, and irresistibly forming his actions. If this grinding tyrant were to be generally accepted we should have to remodel all our language, all our civilisation. It would be idle to speak any longer of a good man in terms of praise: you might as well break out into the praise of a good egg or a good apple. It would be foolish to blame a murderer or a thief; you

might as well blame a stone for falling on the ground or a cork for rising in the water. This sounds like the language of exaggeration—but it is easy to justify it from the principles of current materialism. "If virtue," says Buckner, "is the result of a current of electricity, then virtue and vice are due to natural organisations—products in the same sense that sugar and vitriol are."

But against the god of a materialist—if it be possible to call him a god—not merely the instincts but the commonsense of mankind rise up in revolt. It will not have him—it feels the degradation of his sway too acutely. Consciousness tells men that this god is an impostor whom they can only own when they chain themselves irresistibly to theory, and let go all the teaching of experience, when they are determined to be blind to the daily experience that tells them that 'if they will, they can.'

And many of the most acute of the materialists have felt the difficulty and endeavoured to meet it. They have, so to speak, constructed a god who will at any rate be somewhat less grim, "a Being immense and eternal—Humanity." The positivist sees that there are certain instincts in man's nature—a craving for reality—a passion for the infinite which nothing purely physical can satisfy. He sees that man cannot live without religion; so he sets up his god, the great Being—Humanity—he asks us to prostrate ourselves before the sum total of human

flesh and blood ; not before an idealised abstraction which might conceivably be separated from human degradation and weakness, but before the human family with its crimes, its brutalities, its terrible possibilities of degradation. Positivism is the desperate refuge of those who want to provide for the needs in human nature which they cannot ignore, and who seek, by turning the lights down, to create an impression of mystery. "We men," it has been well said, "know man too well to care to worship him." What satisfaction could there be for our best aspirations—what power to rid us of our bad selves—in the worship of the totality of human beings ? Even the cynic is wiser than the positivist.

If this were all, we might almost say that the First Commandment had done its work. But then there is deism, and deism, though it does not "shew us the Father," does at any rate present us with a god from whom we need not turn with loathing or laughter. It presents us with a god who is related to the world as its Creator, but who, having created it, leaves it to itself ; who keeps himself out of the way in a kind of magnificent inactivity, and leaves the creatures that he has made to settle things as they will, and to work them out as well as they can. He is in no sense the father, nor does he act as a providence. He is distant, abstract, unrecognisable—we can neither pray to him with any hope that he will hear us, or try to love him. He has made

us and left us alone with our struggles, our temptations, our sins, our despair, our vague longings, our unrealised aspirations, our aching, longing human hearts. Again I say such a god presents no attractions to the ordinary man. He *could* do without him, and he would.

IV. But with the god of pantheism the case is rather different. The idea that nature is god finds a hold in the idealism of some natures, and links itself to some of our highest aspirations. "God is the one eternal substance," says Spinoza, "which makes its appearance in the twofold realm of thought and matter." God exists in human thought. Man's thought of god therefore, is god—the only god; human thought is the reason of nature arriving at self-consciousness. "Nature is god," says another, "nature as a spirit, nature as an energy"; and as he points to its glories and beauties, we own that nature at any rate is in many of its aspects a glorious manifestation of God. But we cannot stop here. Nature has an ugly side which on the Christian hypothesis is accounted for by sin. Is that ugly side Divine also? Is the cruelty of nature—the cruelty incidental to the great law of the survival of the fittest—is that God also? Or again, we ourselves are a part of nature, we are linked in all sorts of ways to the physical; are we God? And if in a moment of enthusiasm over the greatness and goodness of some of our race we might be tempted to

say, "yes, we are God," we are beaten back by the recollection that then not only our souls but our bodies, not only our virtues but our vices are god also—possessors of the Divine energy—expressions of the Divine Will—or to put it into plain English, murder, adultery, theft, meanness, lying, are possessors of the Divine energy, expressions of the Divine Will. We are getting very nearly back to the worship of some energy of nature, Baal or Astarte, with all its hideous consequences as history shews them, when we are forced to acknowledge a principle like this.

The real attraction of pantheism is that it assures man of his real union with the source of his own being, and of the universal life around him; it gets rid of his loneliness, it binds him to the great forces of nature, to the rush of life around him. It is a great protest against banishment of God from His own world; and, so far as it is true to this, we may very well recognise its provisional religious value. It often represents a noble plea that God shall not be banished from contact with humanity. Moreover, without any question, the higher Christian thought of our own day owes much of its form to the philosophy of Schelling and Hegel and Spinoza. The weakness of pantheism lies in the fact that it allows the manifestations of God to bury and obscure His Personality. Hence it becomes morally enervating. For we cannot conceive of duties owed, except

in some very vague fashion, to a spirit of existence or to a torrent of energy. We cannot love and trust, much less worship, our own self-consciousness as we must do if we believe that in each reflecting mind God has become conscious of Himself; we cannot hate moral evil if we believe that the activity of the Absolute is manifested, as in the noble heroism of St Paul, so also in the murder and selfishness of Herod. As pantheism advances, moral distinctions get blurred, the sense of sin dies out, wrong becomes only relative right.

While then we cannot but be alive to the beauty of much of the pantheistic literature, while we cannot help seeing that its view of Nature is much higher than the stupid animal view of it with which many Christians are satisfied, and which some so-called Christian teachers are contented to expound—as though Nature were nothing but a universal provider on a large scale, whose inspirations we had exhausted when we had kept a huge Harvest Festival; though we may thankfully own that pantheism has had a provisional value and kept religious feeling alive in Germany, where materialism would have downright killed it—yet we have to come back to the First Commandment. Pantheism gives us no real substitute for God, to which our heart can cling. Its identification of God with Nature ends with losing Him altogether, as a Person to Whom we can cling and Who understands us. In the presence of

the beauties of Nature our sensibilities may be stirred to a semblance of religious feeling, as Goethe is believed to have said that he felt he could pray on a mountain top ; but directly we begin to pray "Our Father, Who art in Heaven," to the living God Who knows our struggles, our weakness, our sins, our despair, we feel the difference. "He Who is" *shines* through nature, *speaks* through nature, but He Who is is not Nature. "I asked the earth," says Augustine,* "and it said 'I am not He,' and all that is on it made the same confession. I asked the sea and the depths and the creeping things that have life, and they answered 'We are not thy God, look thou above us.' I asked the breezes and the gale, and the whole air with its inhabitants said to me, 'I am not thy God ; Anaximenes is in error.' I asked the heaven, the sun, the moon, the stars. 'We too,' they said, 'are not the God Whom thou seekest.' And I said to all the creatures who surround me : 'Ye have said to me of my God that ye are not He, tell me something of Him.' And with a great voice they answered : *Ipse fecit nos*, He it is Who made us."

V. After all, it may be said, "to what end is all this?" We are Christians, we believe in a Heavenly Father, we will have none of these false gods, we are true to Him Who sent His Son to declare Himself to us. We will have none other gods before Him.

* St Aug. Conf., x. 6.

Ah, brethren, is it so ; is our allegiance really given to the Father, to the God of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, to God Whom Christ manifests, to the Heavenly Father, the Father of yourself and all men, in Whom we are brethren ?

Is there not a danger and a dread lest we satisfy ourselves with giving no allegiance to any false god ; is there not a danger and a dread that though we worship no false gods, neither law nor humanity nor the absolute in nature nor aught else, we have still forgotten our Heavenly Father ; that when we come to worship Him there is no reverence, no self-giving, no fire, only a dreamy contemplation of self or others ; that, when we sin, we do not fear Him ? We hate to be humiliated by the bad opinion of others, but we do not fear His eye. If we lost God from our creed, would anything be really taken from us ? Should we not go on much as we do, paying visits, receiving visits, gossiping, trifling, frittering away our time in nothing that is worth doing ? We should miss no light on our sorrows, or restraint on our pleasures ; the sunlight and the darkness of life would remain. Ah, let us look deeper ; we shrink from the unbeliever, we pity the idolater, perhaps we shudder at the atheist. Have we ourselves barred the doors against God by a strange reluctance to think of Him, to own Him ? Have we ceased to think of Him till He has faded into a name, a shadow, a memory ? Do we need the First Commandment, because we have

drifted by self-indulgence into the worst form of atheism ; the worst because the hardest to cure, the atheism of the heart—the atheism that does not care—the atheism that blocks our Churches and defiles our Altars ? May it not be the case that we who have no knowledge of philosophy or science, and no interest in religious speculation, and who pride ourselves on being orthodox Christians, have no other gods before Him, because we have no god at all ?

SERMON III.

SEPTUAGESIMA SUNDAY, 1893.

“Thou shalt not make to thyself any graven image, or any likeness of any thing that is in heaven above, or that is in the earth beneath, or that is in the water under the earth : Thou shalt not bow down thyself to them, nor serve them : for I the Lord thy God am a jealous God, visiting the iniquity of the fathers upon the children unto the third and fourth generation of them that hate Me, and shewing mercy unto thousands of them that love Me and keep My commandments.”—
EXODUS xx. 4, 5, 6.

THE Second Commandment forbids a different sin from the first. The first secures the worship of the true God by excluding all other so-called gods ; the second goes a step further and forbids the worship of Jehovah under any image or symbol. So important is this prohibition considered to be by God Himself, that it is supported by a special threat of His wrath on those who disobey it and their descendants, and by a declaration that God's mercy will be shewn to thousands of generations of men who love Him, and who show their love towards Him by keeping this Commandment.

The subsequent history of Israel shews that this Commandment was very necessary for them. In the wilderness they began to worship God under the image of a calf—they dishonoured Jehovah in the fashion described by the Psalmist : “ Thus they

turned their glory into the similitude of a calf that eateth hay." This worship of the golden calf was not a transgression of the First Commandment—it was not the worship of a false god, but of Jehovah Himself under the form of a calf. And this worship of the calves was a perpetual trouble in Israel. When Jeroboam wished to prevent the people from going up to Jerusalem, he did not dare to set up any strange God, but he instituted the feast of tabernacles at Dan and at Bethel in honour of God Who brought them forth out of Egypt, and he introduced again the calf as the symbol of Jehovah. So, throughout the writings of the prophets, we find remonstrances against calf worship, though it is always recognised as a less grave sin than the worship of the gods of the heathen, and a marked distinction is drawn between the worship of the calf and of Baal.

The special sin, against which this Commandment is directed, arose from an unworthy conception of God. Any symbol attempting to portray the Divine Nature must be dishonouring to Him Whom "no man hath seen," and must lead to that irreverence which is the solvent of faith. Our Lord taught us to pray first "Hallowed be thy Name," because we can never ask God profitably for anything unless we reverence Him. On the same principle, the Second Commandment stands at the beginning of God's Law to emphasise the great necessity of reverence.

The primary meaning of this Commandment no longer needs enforcement. There is no longer any disposition to worship Jehovah under any symbolical form, whether of a calf or anything else. Even if anywhere excessive honour seems to be paid to pictures and statues of Our Lord or His mother, this can hardly be strictly said to be a breach of the Second Commandment. For the essential sin, against which the Second Commandment is directed, is the low conception of the Divine Being which is involved in representing Him as adequately symbolised by any created thing ; and this would not be involved in any excessive reverence for statues or pictures, which only attempt to pourtray Christ's humanity. When God came in such a form, that He could be seen and handled as the Son of Man, He satisfied that craving which, in earlier ages, required restraint. He shewed that God could be seen and known and worshipped as man, without danger of idolatry. No doubt pictures and images of Christ may be held in a superstitious reverence, and may in that way weaken our sense of unseen realities. But it would be as uncharitable to stigmatise the reverence paid to them as idolatrous as to call our regard for the relics of a dead child or friend idolatrous. Iconoclasm, under whatever guise it poses, is as wanting in lucidity as it is in charity ; while the faults of character which it breeds and fosters are certainly far more serious than any which it is

likely to cure. It is possible, but only just possible, that a very uneducated Christian might think that the material atoms composing a painting or statue, which represented Christ, were more sacred in themselves than the atoms composing a chair or a table. Such an idea would shew a certain confusion of thought, but it would not involve a breach of the Second Commandment.

No ; the danger now has passed to that inner region, where it is more deadly still. The Second Commandment in the letter forbids the outward act which resulted in the making and worship of the calf ; to forbid that now is unnecessary ; that danger has passed away ; no one now would be so stupid or so childish as to degrade the Father by thinking of Him, or by worshipping Him, under such a form as though it represented Him. But do we never degrade Him by thinking wrongly about Him, by imagining Him to be other than He is ?

The Second Commandment has still a meaning—it is the safeguard of the imagination. It bids us, first of all, think of God, as He has revealed Himself—as the Father ; it forbids the misuse of the imaginative faculty in thinking of Him as other than He is. This is its deepest lesson. It is the germ thought which prescribes all high and reverent thought about God. God is to be honoured with our imagination. And then, in order that we may make it capable of honouring Him, its use is to be strictly restrained ;

it must not run riot and construct false views of life, or paint false and bad pictures within us and dwell on them. It needs restraint ; it needs also cultivation. It can never be said too strongly that to use your imagination aright you must spiritualise it. "Blessed are the pure in heart, for they shall see God,"—they and only they. You must keep its delicate fibre untarnished ; otherwise you cannot see that *which is*, the real, the Divine.

There is nothing on which, perhaps, it is more necessary to insist than on this, especially with young people. Fancy is free—free as air. Who would check fancy as long as it runs to innocent dreams of fairies and elves, as long as it peoples the world with the bright innocent forms in which childhood delights? Who would weaken the most needed lesson, which grows out of a right use of the imaginative faculty, viz., that all that we can see with our eyes is only the veil of a higher and more beautiful world beyond sight? Who that knows the real mind of little children is not sensible of the fact that there is often a deeper truth hidden in their day-dreams than all our philosophies will ever arrive at? But that is true only during the period of the unself-conscious imagination. That stage passes away, and then the imagination becomes self-conscious; instead of giants and fairies, self becomes the central figure, and then there are the pitfalls and the precipices all around—then the unheeding steps go and gather

poison as if it were honey, and chew the henbane as if it were fruit.

The Second Commandment is the safeguard of the imagination ; it keeps us true to high conceptions of God : it forbids us to imagine Him as a God from Whom we should shrink if He were a man—a non-natural Being ; it forbids any degradation in our thought of Him. In order to lay hold of its spirit, we must discipline the imagination so that we may be able to use it aright : we must train it by keeping it from degradation, but especially by filling it with all that is beautiful and true. For both in the disciplining of the imagination in ourselves and in the training of it in others, the “Thou shalt not,” the mere laws of prohibition and restraint are of little use. Practically we shall find that the only way not to exercise the imagination wrongly is to exercise it rightly. If we would keep it from base uses, we must put it to noble uses. “We must walk in the Spirit” if we are not to “fulfil the lusts of the flesh.” The Divine law for us is positive. The grim sign posts, that keep us out of the woods by assuring us that guns and mantraps are to be found there, will not give us of themselves the benefits of healthy exercise : they may keep us from dangers, they will not give us fresh air. The only way of keeping the imagination from poison is by presenting it with its true food. Give it real loveliness to dwell on and it will reject the sham, the pretentious,

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the unworthy. This is true as regards all studies and pursuits which train the imagination ; and it is true also, as regards the way in which everything is taught. Certain studies do affect us powerfully, if rightly presented. Street songs and music hall snatches may satisfy your earlier cravings for rhythm or musical sequence, but as you become educated you do not need to be told that there are grave faults in these jingles ; you discover it by yourself. You sit entranced before the genius of Mozart or Mendelssohn, or Wagner and the former things are passed away ; a new world has opened to you ; your imagination has grown and has risen to higher things.

In painting the same law holds good. The undisciplined imagination revels in flaming colours and coarse realism ; it has little appreciation of what is really beautiful and suggestive ; it cannot grasp the spirituality of a great painter because it dislikes some details of his pictures, the complexions of the female portraits or their attitudes ; and through dwelling on these his pre-eminent spirituality remains a sealed book. Nothing is more depressing than to listen to the ordinary remarks of the average English woman in a picture gallery ; nothing tells such dismal stories of the results of an education of pothooks and historical facts and latitudes and longitudes than their thin and commonplace comments. There has been in such cases no attempt

at training the imagination to see and to construct the beautiful and the real : it has been left to take its chance. And yet how powerful an agent it is ! * "It is of little consequence," says Mr Ruskin speaking of the education of women, "how many positions of cities she knows, or how many dates of events or names of celebrated persons—it is not the object of education to turn woman into a dictionary ; but it is deeply necessary that she should be taught to enter with her whole personality into the history she reads ; to picture the personages of it vitally in her own bright imagination, to apprehend with her fine instincts the pathetic circumstances and dramatic relations, which the historian too often eclipses by his reasoning and disconnects by his arrangements : it is for her to trace the hidden equities of divine reward and catch sight through the darkness of the fateful threads of woven fire that connect error with retribution."

We hear of strikes for all sorts of purposes ; how much one would like to hear of a strike of children against the dates and facts which only stuff the memory !

Or again think of the study of poetry as a means of training the imagination. The Bible itself by its structure should have taught us the educational value of poetry. The prophets and Psalmist were divinely inspired and their inspiration could only

* "Sesame and the Lilies" (6th edition).

find its outlet in the language of poetry ; the most graphic of the Gospels is a poem in substance if not in form. The poet opens to men a new world, the real world—not the world of the newspaper writer or of the collector of drawing-room gossip,—but the real world. He makes an image of mankind. He shews the way in which the human heart acts in many circumstances and relations of life. He makes his readers sympathize with these varied events and these unknown men. So the reader sees in others his own human nature ; he sympathizes with persons he never saw. The sense of a deep underlying brotherhood takes possession of him, and with the consequent expansion comes the arousing of his whole spiritual nature. The poetic imagination is always making disciples, by investing ordinary scenes and men with a new interest. To kindle men's hearts by a great poem ; to make men understand other men and nature, and feel with other men and nature, is divine work ; while to elevate oneself by the study of such work is the best and most healthy way of training the imagination.

It is impossible in this connection to pass over the question how far the reading of fiction is healthy for the imagination. Unquestionably a tale with a degrading motive and bad tone must be the worst sort of graven image to seek out and bow before—must tend to daub hideous pictures on the inward

temple. We may very well divide works of fiction into good and bad, as far as their influence on the imagination goes. But a bad novel in this sense need not paint vile situations or have an unhealthy tone; it need be only vulgar and stupid in order to have the worst effect. Few novels could be more deteriorating than the lower forms of exciting religious literature—the average Temperance tract or the stories of the Salvation Army type, or, in fact, any thrilling presentations of overstrained situations. On the other hand the best romance becomes dangerous, directly it creates such an interest as to make the ordinary life uninteresting, and to increase the morbid craving for scenes, in which we shall never be called upon to act. This is really the only enduring test about fiction; so far as it widens our tastes or our sympathies, so far as it makes us live in other lives, so far as it stretches us to a wider interest in human nature, so far as it enlarges our charity, it is good; but just so far as it tends to dissipate our energies, to make us sigh for unattainable circumstances, to make things, that must be, seem uncongenial, to that extent it poisons the imagination.

We must settle this for ourselves—it is part of our responsibility. The hard task comes when we have to settle it for others. It is so little that we can settle. For, leaving out of the question books which have obviously a low tone and a base purpose, what

people extract out of an ordinary work of fiction is just what they *can* extract. *Trahit sua quemque voluptas*. Each will gather from romance food for his or her own disposition. The subtle psychological interest, which invests George Meredith's works with such a deep interest for those who can appreciate it, is marred and spoiled for others by their consciousness of his high colours and his fondness for strong situations. In fiction if anywhere 'one man's meat is another man's poison.' "Those," says Mr Ruskin, "who are naturally proud and envious will learn from Thackeray to despise humanity, those who are naturally gentle to pity it, those who are naturally shallow to laugh at it." One could not find a more epigrammatic description of the varied effects of a single author on varying temperaments, and what is true of Thackeray in a marked fashion is true of nearly every writer of romance. A writer may even try to do harm and may not succeed, in the case of any honest and good heart. The writer, who under a thin veil of a badly constructed plot, deals with real or supposed religious difficulties may, after all, not be found to have unsettled religious beliefs. It is more than possible that such a book may have been found to have created in some healthy minds a strong resistance to the idea that the convictions of a lifetime would be destroyed by a walk through a library. So that it cannot be safely laid down that

the object of a work of fiction may not succeed in defeating itself; though it may be generally laid down that books meant to illustrate a theory or push a supposed social convention out of its place have little real influence; they create more antagonisms than they make conversions. For the imaginative faculty within man dislikes above all things to have its interest, as it were, harnessed to a waggon, and to be forced to drag burdens upon which it did not calculate. The novel, with a purpose too obviously expressed upon it, is regarded with much the same feelings as the magazine article which turns out to be rather a poor sermon.

These then are a few thoughts and cautions about the cultivation of imagination on its positive side which may be useful to some of us. One word more. I must not seem to forget or to ignore the extent to which the imagination may sin directly against the Second Commandment, in its low and unworthy conceptions of God. As long as we form intellectual conceptions of God which are untrue, as long as we paint Him as a revengeful Nemesis and not as the Father manifested in the Son, Whose love and pity stretch to a thousand generations in them that seek Him—so long do we break the Second Commandment and make graven images in our hearts. And, as it is plainly set before us in this Commandment, our descendants lose by our misuse

of imagination as well as ourselves. Many have stumbled at the justice of the declaration that God visits the sins of the fathers unto the third and fourth generation. It is only a Hebraic method of stating what we all know, that if you lose your money your son will be poorer—that because “the fathers have eaten sour grapes, and the children’s teeth are set on edge.” Every new age inherits the confusion, the difficulty and the suffering entailed by the follies and crimes of the ages before. We do not object to the benefits we inherit from our ancestors; there is no part of life in which it is not true to say, “other men laboured and we have entered into their labours.” Our just laws, our political institutions, our freedom, our order—we owe them to the wisdom and courage of our ancestors. Our literature, our principles of truth, our industry, our honest self control, our moral discipline—we owe to past centuries. We cannot have the good heritage without the other. All that the Second Commandment insists on is that the tares, which the fathers have sown, will come up as well as the wheat; but it teaches us that the good is more enduring, for while the bad lasts only to the third or fourth generation, the good endures to the thousandth generation.

It were far better if instead of making grievances about the operation of a law which gives us very much, we were to try more to hand on and to

improve the noblest and best traditions of our race ;
and especially to hand down the highest view of the
Father and the deepest love and reverence for Him
as the most inestimable of all blessings, which will
endure to the thousandth generation.

SERMON IV.

SEXAGESIMA SUNDAY, 1893.

“Thou shalt not take the Name of the Lord thy God in vain, for the Lord will not hold him guiltless that taketh His Name in vain.”
—EXODUS xx. 7.

LIKE the Second, the Third Commandment had a special significance owing to the circumstances in which it was first promulgated. God had just revealed Himself to Moses by a name Jehovah which meant a great deal, which had a special significance for the chosen people. It recalled the promises made to Abraham hundreds of years before; it was an earnest of the fulfilment of those promises hundreds of years after; it bound together the past, the present, the future; it assured them of the greatness of their past history, their present calling and their future destiny—that all that was bound together in God. The name Jehovah is to them the revelation of what has been, is and will be. They stand there as a nation with a history, with a present task, with a great and magnificent future; face to face with Him Who is—“I am that I am”—the eternal self-existence, with Whom time is not; Who is the God of Abraham, Who died centuries before,

as He is the God of those standing before the Mount, as He is the God of Apostles and martyrs who as yet are unborn. All the sense of relationship to the past and to the future ; all the conviction that their present is the outcome of their past and the seed of their future—so essential for the development of a nation's life—is bound up and asserted and fixed in the new Name that is revealed to Moses, in the Name Jehovah.

So this Commandment about not taking the Name of God in vain came just when their minds were full of this new Name, Jehovah, and gave it that special sacredness to which their own instinct was prompting them. They felt that this Name carried them back to everything that was precious in the history of Israel ; it reminded them in their darkest days that past, present and future were all bound together in God—the God Who was and is and shall be their God. In those days names had a significance which they have now lost. The names of men and women stood for something, told something about the character or the office. The name of a child was not an arbitrary and unmeaning label, like our modern names are, chosen because it has a pleasant sound or a family association. In those days names were given (as in the case of Samuel) in reference to the circumstances of birth or to the hopes formed about them ; or names were changed, as in the case of Jacob and Abram or afterwards Peter and Paul,

according to the destiny marked out for them by God Himself. So that the idea of the Name of God (which brought so much to the mind of any Jew) having a special sacredness in itself would not appear to them to be strange and forced.

And we see in their after history how deeply this Commandment went home. So great was the awe with which the name Jehovah became invested that it came to be regarded as a secret not to be mentioned to the heathen nations, with whom they came in contact. In reading the Scriptures they never pronounced it, but substituted Elohim for it ; there is even a tradition that it was heard but once a year when it was uttered by the High Priest on the great day of Atonement.

The fact that forgetfulness of the spirit, in obedience to the bare letter, often marred the Jewish observance of this Commandment is no matter of surprise. It has done so, it does so, in the Christian Church. To utter the Name of God with bated breath or to keep His Name as too sacred for utterance was then found quite compatible with absolute forgetfulness of His other claims, and even with idolatry. Nevertheless the Commandment had a strong protective tendency. It was the safeguard of outward reverence ; its literal interpretation kept the Jews safe as a nation from that shocking profanity which has sometimes disgraced the conversation of nominal Christians. It had this distinct effect

and it is a great one. It is our privilege to know God by a Name which brings Him far nearer to us than Jehovah; we know Him by a Name which connotes the closest love, the most protective interest, by the Name of Our Father. The Name of Father is no mere fashion of speech; it describes to us the inmost Nature and Character of God. Christ has made it possible for us to know the Father, and so to know God. "The Father Himself loveth you" is His revelation of the inmost significance of its meaning. Yet though every feeling of reverence and gratitude bids us use that wondrous Name with awe and recollection, we can offer no mere ceremonial homage to His Name. It is Himself we reverence, it is Himself in His Nature, His Will, His Character, for being what He is and what He has told us that He is.

And so our reverence for Himself spreads over all that is connected with Him—over man made in His image whatever may be his outward conditions; over all that is affected by His Name, all that is associated with His worship, the Bible, the Ministry, the Sacraments. Our reverence is shewn, not by unwillingness to mention His Name, but by that inward prostration of heart and soul and spirit before Him which affects and colours all our outward actions. All external reverence is the result of this inward awe. This is very much misunderstood and it may be well to say a few words about it. We are

often exhorted to reverence in these days as if it were an outward thing ; there are certain outward acts said to be reverent and we are told that to omit them is to be wanting in reverence. To make it quite clear, such outward acts as bowing to the Altar and making the sign of the Cross are said to be reverent. Certainly they may be, if they mean anything. If making the sign of the Cross means that you are filled with a sense of the great love of our Master and only Saviour in dying for you, that you desire to keep it alive in that fashion, it may be a token of real reverence. But it may be, it often looks as if it were, the merest form, the most shallow and meaningless ceremony.

Certainly the body has its share in reverence ; the twenty-four elders fall down and worship the lamb. Certainly no one full of reverence could possibly sit on a chair and stare in front of him, while imploring God to have mercy on him. Kneeling in prayer, standing in praise, bowing the head at the Name of Jesus are outward tokens of reverence, but they are not reverence itself. Reverence is an inward thing ; it comes from the sight of God, from the spiritual vision. "Woe is me," cries Isaiah, "for mine eyes have seen the King, the Lord of Hosts."

The Third Commandment is, when we consider it deeply, not only the safeguard of reverence ; it is also the protection of truth and honesty. Falsehood arises really from indifference to the real nature of

God. If God is a fetish, then you may lie. If He is a living Person, you cannot. It reminds us of what we so easily forget that a Christian speaks always in the Name of God, that our words are always spoken before Him as belonging to Him, that falsehood of any kind is a taking His Name in vain. And this is so seldom insisted upon. We bid children speak the truth and base the injunction on no such high ground ; the Ninth Commandment, not to bear false witness, is the only one which we often treat as though it applied to truth-telling ; we dwell on untruth as an injury only to others or as shameful in itself. Our teaching is not deep enough. To lie is to take God's Name in vain. We have almost forgotten that the Third Commandment gives the strongest support to truthfulness that its meaning for us Christians is that in every word we speak, we speak in the Name of God, as His representative, and in His Presence.

At special times we recognise the cogency of this *e.g.*, in those words of the marriage service which effect the uniting bond we appeal to His special unifying power, for we declare those that are married to be joined together in the Name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Ghost *i.e.*, by the same unifying power which makes God One. Again in the courts of justice, we declare that we voluntarily recognise His authority and Presence not only that He hears what we say but that those who hear us,

recognize that we are men who speak in His Name, and who are not afraid to call Him to witness to our truth. We thereby recognise the fact that society rests on a Divine foundation ; that the witness who gives evidence is discharging a function that arises from the Divine order of society. Nor can I help saying here (whatever exceptions there are, which ought to be made and are made in cases where men deny the existence of God) that the recognition in a special fashion of the sacred character of the administration of justice is on the highest grounds to be valued and preserved. It is said indeed sometimes that it only leads to perjury, but that is only to say that we cannot ensure that men shall tell the truth by any outward means. What we can do is to shew our sense of the supreme importance of truth. And though we cannot always prevent perjury, it does not need a very extensive knowledge of human nature to understand that the oath does secure truth-telling, in many cases, when falsehood would otherwise be easily uttered. Because no oath will bind the hardened perjurer, it is foolish to give up what in the case of average humanity is doubtless a very valuable safeguard.

But though such recognitions of the Divine Order on which society is based are valuable, yet Our Lord points out in His Sermon on the Mount that, in the ideal of Christian intercourse, an oath is superfluous—"yes" and "no" are all that need be said—because

the Christian remembers that God hears him. The man who remembers God's Presence tells the truth. He needs no oath to confirm his statement. On the other hand the man who always offers to attest all his sayings by oath is generally a liar. "Yes" and "no" are quite strong enough for those who remember that they speak in God's Name, and that when they speak untruly they take His Name in vain. And yet alas, how easily, how idly we do take His Name in vain when, *e.g.*, we utter the last slander or the newest bit of gossip, when we neglect to practise that patient devotion to facts, that endeavour to think what is true as in God's sight, which is the only foundation of real truthfulness. For this must ever be remembered that truthfulness is not a matter of accuracy in speech but of inward character. The merely veracious man who speaks the lies which his own heart has framed is not a truthful man; the truthful man is the man who thinks the truth as in God's sight. It is no justification for anyone who repeats a lie to say "I thought that the thing I said was true"—the further question has to be faced, "on what grounds did you think it was true?" or even this, "what sort of a man must you have made yourself to enable you to think it true?" "Truth in the inward parts" is what God is said to require—it is the only truth worth caring for and it is only to be learned by living and thinking and judging, as in God's sight.

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It is said sometimes that Englishmen are less careful about truth than they were once. If that be so, one of the deepest elements in our national greatness is being undermined. For truth has been historically a canonized virtue among us. Our whole history is marked by a regard for what is real, substantial, genuine, by a disgust of shams and impostures, by a fear of professing too much, by an impatience of affectation and pretence, by the demand that a man should say what he means—say it well if he can, but say it clumsily rather than sacrifice thought to rhetoric—by a dislike of mis-statement and exaggeration, by a sacrifice of form to substance. The conviction that truth was of all things the most precious, that truth seeking, truth speaking, was man's supreme duty, man's highest blessedness—has been enwoven in our national life. This was the deep fruitful idea implanted, at the awakening dawn of thought, in the infant civilisation of the North. It became rooted, strong, obstinate; it bore many and various fruits; it was the parent of fervent belief; the parent too of passionate scepticism; it produced at one time persecution and intolerance, it produced at another indignant uprisings against abuses and impostures.*

The history of the Reformation in its inwardness is the history of a national protest for truth and for reality against shams and impostures—against a

* Cf. Church on "Christianity and the Teutonic Races," p. 329.

Paganized Christianity, against a tolerated unreality. Woe be to us if it be really true that as a nation we are losing that high standard of truth and reality which is thus enwoven in our history. "A Christian man's word is his oath," is a form of speech which has been well understood among us. It would be difficult to epitomize more exactly and definitely the real meaning of the Third Commandment for us Christians. We keep that Commandment entirely, so far as we live and walk in the Presence of God ; for assuredly while we do, we shall speak the truth.

There is one other effect of entering into the spirit of this Commandment which must be dwelt on, because there are signs in our conversation and our literature of its necessity. We take God's Name in vain assuredly when we scoff at anything which either is good or tries to be ; when we sit and criticise those who are labouring to make the world better, when we laugh at their failures and misrepresent their motives. There is a growing habit of sneering at imperfection, of cheapening the moral currency by exposing the inconsistencies of the good. It poses often in our fiction as being wondrously clever ; it sits in that worst of all seats that a man can occupy—the seat of the scornful,—and secure on that throne it caricatures the outward untidiness, the damp and bedraggled garments of those who have hearts that long for righteousness. In certain forms of literature and in some social

circles the scoffing element is the predominant one. It would not be too much to say that some men's reputation for wit and cleverness is founded on their ability to scoff, to sneer, to depreciate! Such persons often attempt to find a justification for their sneers in the inconsistencies of professing Christians. It may be well to see how far it avails them.

Let it be said once and for all that people who try to live Christian lives are sure to present some inconsistencies. They must be inconsistent—all of them for a while—some of them always. They must be inconsistent because their standard is a very high one and it is hard to attain to it in this world: only those, who try to attain to it, know how hard it is. The Christian position is so often misunderstood that it is always worth while restating it. The Christian does not profess to be better than other people; he acknowledges that he often breaks God's Commandments, that he is a sinful man, that he needs Redemption; he knows far better than his critic that he often fails, he weeps bitter tears about these very inconsistencies over which they are chuckling, he is conscious of his sinfulness and of his inability to cure it without help from above, he is clinging to Christ as his Saviour from those very inconsistencies, at which the scoffer is jeering. Seen in this light is not then the whole attitude of scoffing brutal and inhuman? It is like laughing at a wounded soldier on the battle-field; it is like jeering

at a fever-stricken patient in a sick-room ; it is like asking a man to wield a hammer with a broken arm or to jump a wall with a broken leg, and jeering at him because he cannot. Is not the attempt, by whomsoever made, to sadden the heart of the righteous by contemptuous sneers at his failings and inconsistencies, brutal and unfeeling and contemptible ?

Those who try to serve God and to keep His commandments say in the secret of their chambers harder things of themselves than any critics or scoffers can say ; but they say them in the ear of an All pitiful Father Who knows their weakness, of an All Merciful Saviour Whose touch has power to heal, of the Comforter Who is ever at work strengthening and inspiring them to reach higher things. Surely "the Lord will not hold them guiltless" who make that bitter task of repentance harder and more dreary than it is ; who laugh at the wounds of sin or sneer at the defects, of which the man who has them is only too painfully conscious. If you are doing nothing yourself to hallow God's Name, to make His Nature, His Character and Will known and loved by men, at least beware how you scoff at those who, with whatever inconsistencies and whatever infirmities, are trying to maintain His cause.

And this is especially needful to say to the young men of our day, who are too refined to swear, but who think it manly to scoff. "Be sure," said one of the wisest and best of men, "that no one knows so

little of his fellow-man as the scoffer," the cynic who 'walks in darkness because he hates his brother.'* Be sure that the truly wise and understanding man is he who puts himself in his neighbour's place, feels with and for him, sees with his eyes, hears with his ears, and therefore understands him and makes allowances for him and is merciful to him, even as his "Father Which is in heaven is merciful."

* 1 S. John ii. 11.

SERMON V.

QUINQUAGESIMA SUNDAY, 1893.

“Remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy. Six days shalt thou labour, and do all thy work : but the seventh day is the Sabbath of the Lord thy God : in it thou shalt not do any work, thou, nor thy son, nor thy daughter, thy manservant, nor thy maidservant, nor thy cattle, nor thy stranger that is within thy gates : For in six days the Lord made heaven and earth, the sea, and all that in them is, and rested the seventh day : wherefore the Lord blessed the Sabbath day, and hallowed it.”—EXODUS xx. 8-11.

THE institution of the Sabbath began with the law. There is no trace of a Sabbath in the times of the Patriarchs or of any weekly rest or weekly worship. The custom of dividing time into periods of seven days no doubt existed in very early times, and that not only among the Jews. The Egyptians, and the Chaldeans divided time in the same way. * The Greeks who at first divided the month into three periods of ten days each, afterwards found it more convenient to accept the week of seven days. The same division of time had found its way into India ; and the Romans who had a week of eight days almost up to the time of Christ, changed it to one of seven. It is a curious fact also, that a

* Cf. Dale on the “Ten Commandments,” p. 84.

week of seven days was found to exist among the nations of Peru. All this points to the wide dissemination of the account of the Creation given in Genesis.

But though there is this general agreement about the convenience of the seven day period, there is no evidence anywhere that the Patriarchs or any other nation observed one day in the week, either at the beginning or middle or end, as a day of rest or of worship. The saying of Christ that "the Sabbath was made for man and not man for the Sabbath" does not in any way imply that the Sabbath was an institution of universal obligation, but only that like all other ordinances, it was instituted for the sake of the worshipper and not the worshipper for the sake of the ordinance.* He might have said the same of the Passover or Circumcision which are exclusively Jewish ordinances.

It is necessary to assert this because those who are anxious to maintain (in the teeth of St Paul's language, and of the silence of the New Testament about the observance of Sunday), that the law of the Sabbath is still binding, always insist that it is so because the Sabbath was instituted immediately after the Creation—that Adam had to keep it and we must. If Adam had to keep it, there would be no more reason for our following his

* Cf. Dale on the "Ten Commandments," p. 87.

example in that than in any other respect—it would not prove anything either way ; but there is, as a matter of fact, no trace, in the preserved records, of any command to keep any day differently from any other, before the promulgation of the Law. The Sabbath was, like the Passover and the rite of Circumcision, a distinctly Jewish institution as regards its form and observance. It was founded on a Divine command ; it was to be kept not once a week but on a certain day in every week, and it was to be kept to commemorate the completion of the work of Creation, *i.e.*, it was to be kept as an act of faith in God the Creator. After excluding the worship of other gods and of the true God under unworthy forms, after enjoining reverence for His Name in the Third Commandment, it was sought to secure by the Fourth Commandment a definite time for the contemplation of God Himself ; and that this might be secured, rest from labour was enjoined. Of course no outward regulation could ensure the thinking about God on the Sabbath, any more than the command not to take His Name in vain could secure reverence for Himself ; but at any-rate the Sabbath gave to those who chose to do so a weekly opportunity to “be still and know” that Jehovah was God, as well as an occasion of physical rest. But it must be observed in this connection that the letter of the Commandment does not for-

bid recreation on the seventh day, that it only prohibits labour.

We are apt to be misled by the later Pharisaic developments into thinking that the Jewish Sabbath was a gloomy day. The Jewish Sabbath is compared to a Scotch Sunday—that most chilling of modern institutions. It was not so in the beginning. From the earliest it is probable that the Jews regarded it as a day for family parties and friendly festivals, and there are passages in the Christian Fathers which seem to shew that, in later times, these earlier customs were revived. St Augustine tells the Jews of his day that it would be better for them to plough on the Sabbath than to dance. Whether he was right or wrong, it is clear that the Jewish practice in his day forbade ploughing but did not forbid dancing. As a matter of fact the Puritan or rigorous observance of the Sabbath can only find its historical justification in the worst traditions of the Scribes and Pharisees. What the Fourth Commandment made unlawful to the Jews on the seventh day was not pleasure or recreation, but work. They were to rest from labour—that was the only positive command. They were to rest, not because they were tired, but to remind themselves that Jehovah was the Creator of all things, and had delivered them from Egypt, and had given them rest in the Land of Promise. But if a man's own heart did not prompt him to dwell on this, and if

he merely abstained from ordinary week day work, he could not be called a Sabbath breaker. The law only prescribed rest; it did not even require worship.

The Jewish Sabbath was a unique institution—"a most characteristic expression of one of the great ideas of which Judaism was the development."* The whole direct preparation for the coming of the Messiah was permeated by the great conception of which the Sabbath is one development, viz., the necessity of election, and of setting apart as a sign of election. One nation was elected and separated, within the nation one tribe, that of Levi, within the tribe one family, the family of Aaron—in him and his family the idea of election and consecration to God was represented in its ultimate form. So one place, the Temple, was similarly separated, and within the Temple one place, the inner court, was separated, and within the inner court the Holy of Holies. So with property, tithes and first fruits were separated. So also as regards time, one day in every week was separated; and in years, one year was separated, the Seventh year, when no seed was to be sown, and at the end of the seven times seven years there was the year of Jubilee, a rest for the whole land when debts were cancelled and slaves were set free. Through all the provinces of human life, the same idea ran, viz., that God claimed the

* Dale on the "Ten Commandments," p. 95.

world as His own ; and the sign that men owned that claim was to be through their separation of a portion. On this ground to break the Sabbath was to disown and deny God's claim upon men's *time*. Hence the serious penalty attached to it, the penalty of death. The Sabbath was therefore not an arbitrary institution ; it was designed to bring out a necessary idea in the education of Israel, viz., that time belonged to God. Without it they would have forgotten God. The Sabbath was the solemn recalling of God to the mind of the people ; the weekly rest appealed to them as nothing else could, to remember the God of their fathers.

The real purpose of the institution was lost sight of when, through the teaching of the Rabbis, its observance became a bondage and a worry. It was meant for freedom, for release from the bondage of daily toil ; it was meant as well for innocent recreation as for solemn meditation. It was as though God took the side of man against the inevitable hardships of his lot and made rest from work a religious duty. And man retorted on God's goodness in later Judaism by making the Sabbath a burden and a trial !

The Jewish Sabbath passed away when it had served its purpose of preserving the idea of consecration through setting apart ; of applying that principle to time. It was fulfilled on the great Sabbath, when Christ entered into His rest. Henceforth

all time was to be consecrated. As "in Christ Jesus there is neither male nor female, neither bond nor free," so in Him there is neither Sabbath nor Sabbatical year nor year of Jubilee—all time was consecrated. The observance of Sunday in the Christian Church comes to us with quite a different sanction, based on different grounds, from that of the Jewish Sabbath. It rests upon no direct Divine command ; no word is said about it in the New Testament ; it grew up out of those same necessities in man's nature which had been recognised by the Fourth Commandment and which were felt to be still existing ; but its growth was very gradual. For three centuries at least it was marked by no cessation of work, though from the first it was marked by religious worship.

As regards the proportion of time—one day in seven—it was doubtless evolved from the Jewish Sabbath, but there similarity ends : it represented a different spirit and a different idea, its spirit was one not of rest but of aspiration. Its *raison d'être* was not the commemoration of the Creation, but of the Resurrection. When Christ founded the Church and organised a supernatural society, common worship became a social necessity. All who believed must be together for the development of the new life ; and for worship men naturally adopted the day which was associated in their minds with the victory of Christ, which gave rise to this new society. On

the first day the Lord rose again: on the first day His most notable appearances were made: on the first day the Holy Ghost came down from Heaven; what other day could be so suitable for the common worship of those whose object was to commemorate the Resurrection?

Sunday was the Resurrection day in idea as well as in fact, actually as well as by commemoration. The distinguishing mark of Christian men was that they were "risen with Christ"—what else then could they so naturally commemorate as His Resurrection? On the first day they met to break bread and to worship—to receive the Holy Communion and to receive instruction in Christian faith and duty.

So Sunday comes down to us with a distinct mark upon it. It is the day of Resurrection. It is no mere revival of the Jewish Sabbath on a different day: it commemorates a different fact, it is permeated by a different idea; its characteristic observance is not rest but worship. The rest came in after; the idea of worship first laid hold of Christians. There is no word, no hint in the New Testament about abstaining from work on Sunday. The only rule for its observance is that given by St Paul, viz., that on the first day men should lay by in store as God has prospered them, that they may have to give for the support of religion. As time went on, the oppor-

tunities for Christian communion in worship were secured by abstinence from work. The Church grew strong enough to effect this; and in the time of Constantine the courts of law were closed by the imperial edict, and all work except that of agriculturists (in whose favour an exception was made), was suspended. But Constantine's decree was the first public step in establishing the first day of the week, as a day on which there should be secular rest as well as religious worship. The order of things was exactly inverted. In the Fourth Commandment, as given to the Jews there is no mention of worship; then the rest came first, and the worship followed. In the history of the Christian Sunday worship came first and rest followed. In the idea of the Jewish Sabbath, rest was the essence, worship the accident: in the idea of the Christian Sunday worship is the essence and rest is the accident. The rest of the Sabbath was protected by law, and the question had to arise as to what the law allowed and what it forbade. Into the rest of Sunday no divine law enters; it has been won as a privilege, it has to be protected as a right.

To discuss then any questions about Sunday observance, in connection with the Fourth Commandment, is obviously to discuss questions which cannot be settled in that fashion. Sunday comes to us as a great privilege, a magnificent possession; but it

has no possible connection with the Jewish Sabbath, as regards its fundamental idea of observance or even as regards its Divine Sanction.

But this much may be said. The spirit of the Fourth Commandment bids us "serve God truly all the days of our life." That is the sole meaning which the Church of England attaches to it. The Church of England is very direct and plain about the Fourth Commandment. It takes up a wide and consistent position which, coming from the age in which the Catechism was compiled, is not a little remarkable. The explanation of the Third Commandment is that men should honour God's Holy Name and His Word: what could have been more easy and natural and more in conformity with certain modern quasi-religious conceptions than to go on and say that the Fourth Commandment enjoins that men should "honour His Holy Day"? But no such explanation is to be found. The Church Catechism goes deeper and says that all time belongs to God—one day as much as another. There may be observances like the observance of Lent, Ascension Day, Christmas Day, &c., which are sanctioned by the custom of centuries and which deserve our serious recognition; but you cannot go behind the general principle and set up any detail as binding by a direct Divine sanction. Our observance may have behind it the universal custom of the Christian Church; but if the observance of Sunday is urged on

that ground the observance of Ash Wednesday or Lent stands on exactly the same footing as the observance of Sunday. The real attitude in which to approach the question of the religious observing of Sunday or any other day is not to ask "what may I do or may I not do," but "what will best bring home to me as a Christian, the great idea of the Resurrection and of rising above common things to a higher world, which Sunday is designed to bring out? How can I rise to a privilege which the Christian Church won for me in the past and gives me in the present? How can I best safeguard this privilege and hand it down?" These questions every man must answer for himself, though in answering them he must take some account of the religious feelings of those around him. But he must not lay down a hard and fast rule for others as well as himself. This has been done to the great diminution of the spiritual value of Sunday. We have heard of the profanation of Sunday by innocent recreation, which gives no work to anyone and therefore cannot be accused of selfishness. We have heard of sermons in Christian churches accusing those who play such harmless games as cricket or golf or lawn tennis of "profaning the Lord's day." Such diatribes are as ignorant as they are uncharitable; they are revivals of Judaism; they would have just as much sense in them if they were directed against playing cricket and other games every seventh year,

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and a *reductio ad absurdum* of that kind is the best answer to them.

Sunday as an institution has claims upon us of a twofold nature, which may be stated in a rational fashion. We shall best perhaps arrive at a clear conclusion about them by considering them separately.

I. Sunday has the greatest claims upon us as a religious institution resting, not on a Divine command, but on an unbroken tradition of the Christian Church. It has been from the first regarded as a Day of Worship; a day in which Christian men meet together to express their sense of God's goodness by prayer and praise, by communion with Him and with one another in the Holy Sacrament. The Christian Church is a supernatural Body indwelt by the Holy Spirit; and with that fact before us, we cannot help seeing that an unbroken tradition ought not to be lightly set aside. One tradition of the Christian Church about Sunday is that we should worship God, *i.e.*, go to Church. This directly religious observance of Sunday, it is true, rests only on tradition and not on a direct commandment; but it is a tradition so universal, so Catholic in the highest sense, that a man can have very little sense of his higher responsibilities who does not observe it practically, and that too, not grudgingly but thankfully. But that is as far as one can go. The capacities of men for common worship and receiving religious instruction vary very much, and no quanti-

tative theory of devotion ever seems to hold water, when we come to test it. But that some recognition of the duty of religious worship, and of learning or thinking about Divine truth, ought to mark our observance of Sunday, is a broad principle which covers really a good deal of ground and which each individual must carry out for himself.

Only he must carry it out with a sense of responsibility, remembering that Sunday in a crowded life must be a precious spiritual possession. The distinct spiritual value of Sunday is a thing to be carefully insisted on. The question is, how to secure it ; is it by making impossible and burdensome restrictions or by putting the religious observance of Sunday before people as a privilege ? Is it by saying, 'you must' ? Is it not rather by saying,—“here is a chance for you to dwell in a fairer world, to breathe a higher air, to get rid of the soil, the travail, the often littleness of your life, to stand with Christ and His Apostles and every Saint and hero, and every one departed who loved you before the great Father and worship Him ; to read great books or to take in the deep thoughts of great poets and painters and musicians, in a word, to elevate yourself” ?

II. Then again Sunday is a social institution which has a moral value, quite apart from its religious observance. There is an observance of Sunday which rests on purely social grounds and which has

only a religious aspect, so far as all social questions have. On the general propriety of this observance of rest from work all thoughtful men are agreed. It is invaluable to the physical well-being. Those who live, as many of us do, lives into which routine largely enters, can appreciate its intellectual value; even if it only takes the mind out of its accustomed legal or commercial ruts, it does much for it. The more absorbed men are in their business, the more do they need the distraction of Sunday. There is a cynical French epitaph, "He lived a man and died a grocer." It traces in an epigrammatic form the gradual growth of absorptions which Sunday is intended to counteract. "He lived a man and died a banker or a lawyer." Shall it be true of you? Whatever law, written or unwritten, prevents our absorption in any bondage is a moral and intellectual advantage of the highest kind.

It ought then to be stated plainly, especially in the West End of London, that to inflict unnecessary work on others on Sundays, without giving them a compensating holiday on some other day, is a social offence, and therefore in that way a religious one.

It becomes a duty to say that to make any man or woman work seven days a week is a social offence; and that for the double object of enabling them to see their friends and to join, if so disposed, in religious worship, it is most desirable to make Sunday a day of rest as far as possible for those

whom we employ. To keep Sunday, as far as possible, free from any unnecessary work, is for all of us, a social duty—a duty to our fellow-man. If you take out your carriage or give large parties on Sunday, you are really failing in a social duty to those whom you employ ; you are guilty not of desecrating the Sabbath—for there is no Sabbath—but you are guilty of selfishness. But if, after joining in worship, you like to refresh yourself in any way by any game that is lawful on any day, whatever it be, so long as it does not involve the employment of others, it is not either a social offence or a religious one ; in fact if to play games fits you better for your week day work, you are ‘serving God truly all the days of your life’ by playing them.

Possibly this sounds strange to those who have been brought up under Sabbatarian traditions, but it is better for them and for everyone to face the real truth. No Commandment of God bids us do this or not do that on Sunday ; we are absolutely free as far as His law goes ; His Commandment is, whatever you do, do well. But there is a most precious Christian tradition which marks Sunday as pre-eminently the day for public worship ; and there is a strong social tradition, though not so early or so wide, in favour of Sunday rest. The exceptions to the rule of no work, which there obviously must be in any organised society, ought to be, in the case of policemen and others, compensated for by

freedom on some other day, and secondly, so far as the law of the land regulates them, ought to be governed by consideration of the greatest good of the greatest number. It is to my mind a little inconsistent on our part as a nation to refuse to open museums and picture galleries on Sunday afternoon out of regard to the Sunday rest of a few, who could easily have another rest day provided, and to keep open public-houses, which cause every Sunday hundreds of thousands of people to be employed behind the bar. If the Sunday labour of either class is to be considered in reference to its results, surely the first is more defensible.

But we shall save great confusion of thought if we remember the distinction between Sunday as a religious Festival and as a social institution. In respect of the first, worship is its fitting observance, and that consideration of it presents to us the highest view about it ; but further than that, it is worth making any sacrifice to preserve Sunday as a social institution involving rest from labour. Only we must not say that rest from work is prescribed by God's command.

I have felt it my duty to put these matters plainly before you, and have left myself but a moment to dwell on the one aspect which intensifies the spiritual value of Sunday for those who will try to ask not "what must I do, but what is it my privilege to do?" For those who work little on any day, Sunday should be a day of worship but also a day of unsel-

fishness, a day devoted to making the lives of others brighter and happier. This may be done in Sunday schools or in gathering round you those who have little leisure on other days for quiet recreation ; and the opportunity is a very valuable one : it is good for them and it is certainly good for you. We are being forced by all the currents of thought around us to look at the social side of the Christian religion ; and the social side may be developed by brighter Sundays with more recreation and fewer unmeaning restrictions, so long as the great social duty of abstinence from unnecessary labour be kept in mind. But after satisfying the higher claims of religious worship, those who rest all the week will perhaps find no better occupation than in teaching others, who work all the week, to learn how to play on Sundays, instead of leaving them to idle at street corners and loaf in thoroughfares. Those who are unselfish enough to do this may not satisfy all the current religious prejudices of their day, but they will win the blessings of thousands of those toilers whose blessings are worth having ; and they will pass on with no difficulty and no sense of strangeness to that new Jerusalem, whose distinct feature it is that *the children are playing in its streets ; within whose gates the Eternal Father, in the midst of His redeemed children, delights in their happiness as much as He does in their goodness.

* Zechariah viii. 5.

SERMON VI.

FIRST SUNDAY IN LENT, 1893.

“Honour thy father and thy mother : that thy days may be long upon the land which the Lord thy God giveth thee.”—EXODUS xx. 12.

I. IT must be the case with many of us that our first thought, as we turn to this commandment, must be tinged with a great sadness. “Honour thy father and thy mother.” What memories the words which we learnt to lisp as children call up. Well is it for us if those memories be not marred by a deep regret or a terrible remorse. What recollections the words awaken of that first overshadowing love and tenderness which taught us the meaning of the word “love,” which bore with our infant waywardness and our childish forgetfulness, and alas, alas! with our moments of rebellion and our often petulance and our cruel misunderstanding. “Honour thy father and thy mother.” Ah, what would not some of us give to tell them how we honour and reverence and almost worship the memory of that earliest relationship, that background of consolation and consideration and tenderness and endurance, that nothing else—no other relationship, no other tie, however

sweet, however near, ever exactly takes the place of. To many, let us hope, these words come home not like a commandment but as an assertion of the most blessed of all privileges ; they want no explanation ; there is no need to dwell on them ; they touch at once their deepest feelings even if they re-awaken a sense of the great want—a void which never has been filled. “Honour thy father and thy mother.” Yes, thereby the Divine seal is here set upon the noblest and best feelings of our nature. You see those feelings in their most attractive form in the tender devotion which the best men display towards their mothers. That always touches us. Whatever influences the circumstances of the world at that time and the peculiarities of the Jewish race may have had on the form of some of the other Commandments, however necessary it may be to look on them as germ-thoughts which must expand in order to be correlative to our present response to them—here we are face to face with that which never can wear out or change its essential form or outgrow the range of the highest response which could even then be given to it ; here we are face to face with that which changeth not, with no temporary safeguard for preserving reverence or giving a distinctive character to a portion of time, but here we are face to face with an abiding relationship which will remain while the world lasts ; a relationship full of power, full of sweetness on both sides, full of deep

and inexhaustible mystery, here we are brought into touch with Joseph the son of Jacob, and David the son of Jesse, and Jesus the son of Mary, and Augustine the son of Monica, and with countless relationships like these. We find the same sweet and tender recognition of that relationship in them which we find in a thousand homes all round us at the present time, and which will be found in palaces and cottages, whatever changes the world may survive. For the filial relationship is eternal ; it may accidentally be marred here and there by untoward circumstances, but in the great mass it asserts itself with all its consequences ; and its instinct in the last age as in the wilderness before Sinai, is expressed and satisfied by the command : " Honour thy father and thy mother." And there are clear and definite reasons why apart from all other things we owe this honour as a debt. For to our parents we owe the greatest of all gifts, the gift of life. I say the greatest of all gifts. Accidentally no doubt the pessimist influences of this or that age may cause some to depreciate the gift of life and to say that their birth was a calamity ; there may be times so wearisome, there may be times when hopes seem so blighted and life's purposes so disastrously defeated, when the past is so charged with regrets or the future so overshadowed by fears that we may wish that we had never been born ; but in the long run with

most men the conviction will always prevail that such a discontent is the product of ignoble or unworthy moods, and, in the end, if not here, it must yield to the vision of that life in the world beyond, which makes earth's hardest trials seem to be but "a light affliction." To our parents then we owe what we can never repay, however much at some moments we depreciate it, the gift of life—that life which makes it possible for us to live with God, to be like God for ever. Nor is this all. For years we were dependent on them not only for the necessities of life, but for the care without which we should have died; and their wisdom, their kindness, their influence have been with us and about us for years before we can remember anything, when we could make no intelligent response.

No contrast is more painful than that which is sometimes presented to us in the space of a few short years between the unwearied care and tenderness of parents and the apparent forgetfulness and ingratitude or flippant want of respect, which we have seen meted out to them as their only reward. Nothing more lamentable is ever seen or heard. It may be of course that the foolish fondness that has never learned to say "no," that has substituted softness for kindness, and excuses for reproof, may be sometimes the cause of such a miserable requital; but however caused, the

tragedy of the contrast between the watchful care exercised and the lavish affection bestowed on the one side, and the subsequent coldness and neglect displayed on the other, is none the less moving. The wounds which are dealt by those once spoilt children, who have grown up to be selfish and ungrateful men and women, are none the less grievous, none the less tragic, because there is some account of them to be given which may explain, though it cannot justify, their infliction. The son who refuses to honour his father and mother is always an outcast from the kingdom. He must be destitute of any of the higher feelings of our nature. He has forgotten what no true-minded man can ever let himself forget. He has ignored the deep underlying fact of the parental relationship. For there is in the parental relationship a revelation of one of the great mysteries of the Divine Life. The father reflects in some wondrous fashion God Himself to the child; and the child in honouring his father honours the highest symbol of what God is to us all. It is from forgetfulness of this that the failure of mutual obligation on either side so often arises. The child gets its idea of God from its parents; their love is its earliest experience of that overshadowing tenderness, which is in God Himself in its fulness. There are, of course, modifications and limitations of this, which result from the infirmities of human nature. These may sometimes

be so predominant as to make such a conception difficult and impossible. There are wicked and cruel parents who have apparently killed within them the strongest instinct. We know it to our sorrow and to our shame. But such cases are exceptional ; and generally we may say that, with whatever drawbacks and infirmities, parents do convey to their children some image—the only one that they can then grasp—of the love and tenderness of the Invisible God, that they do enable them to frame a conception of Him not wholly unworthy, that it is still true to say that the ultimate idea of the relationship between parents and children is to be found in the relationship between God and all mankind. When once this is grasped, the moral ground of the command “Honour thy father and thy mother” is seen in its absolute fulness.

II. What, let us pass on to ask, does it include ? The word honour speaks for itself to all those who wish to fulfil the Commandment. It speaks for itself as no definition can. It includes obedience and love and respect, it requires these in their most literal sense in childhood and youth, it demands them even in later life in transformed and modified forms. To honour one's parents may conceivably be difficult in later life, if unhappily troubles have arisen, such as do arise sometimes ; it may seem unreal to say that we honour those who are unwise, unreasonable, or even selfish. There is a disposition on the part

of many to constitute themselves judges of such matters, and to act on the principle that they will honour their parents just so far as they themselves conceive them to be worthy of honour. The position looks plausible enough at first sight. It is possible to ignore the ineffable mystery of the relationship; and to ask with a bland smile, "how can I respect anyone just because she happens to be my mother, or love anyone because he chances to be my father?" The answer is that God's command is founded not on the approval or disapproval by children of their parents' conduct, but on a deep relationship which nothing can undo. It was the sense of that relationship which caused them to bear with us and love us, even if we were uninteresting and unamiable children, as no doubt other people often thought us. What if in those days they had adjudged us uninteresting and incapable of being loved, in the same way that we now propose to adjudge them? Is not the very fact that we have had the first advantage of the moral ground of the relationship, a reason for our recognising it now? Is it fair, is it honourable, is it worthy to make those judgments which we form of them now, the ground for neglecting our duty; when they never made those judgments to which we were possibly very much more open, the ground for repudiating their care of us? Possibly some of us are so pre-eminently pleased with ourselves that we can never imagine ourselves to have been other-

wise than charming: yet is it not the case often now that we, from the outside, regard with feelings of a decided character, some children who are the apples of their parents' eye, that we wonder what they can see in those who seem to us so affected, or so ill-mannered, or so gauche, or so vain, or so silly? And yet to our unthinking irritation their parents still seem blind to all these failings, and only to see those excellencies which our doubtless purblind vision fails to detect. Possibly we may have once had the benefit of a similar blindness. There is an expression which the poor often use about their children which goes to the root of the matter; after all, it has often been said to me, when I was hinting at the possibility of some improvements, "after all, he is our own, and everyone cares for his own." It is that sense of possession which ought to be reciprocated. One's parent is one's own, and to his faults one is bound to try to be blind.

A shrewd man was once giving advice to young clergymen starting on their careers, and his advice took an almost epigrammatic shape: "I advise you," he said, "in your parishes to keep one blind eye and one deaf ear." Golden advice—capable, if acted on, not only of bringing peace to many a distracted parish, but of healing many a family difference. What better advice could one give to a child as to his father's faults than that he should keep one blind eye and one deaf ear?

Perhaps when we were children there was not anything very lovable about us. People were not consumed by any special desire to cultivate our society when they felt out of sorts in any way. *But happily our fathers and mothers bore with us, even found graces and perfections in us which no one else ever discovered, and the very loving instinct that detected the germs of those graces and perfections gave us perhaps courage to aspire to them. Their love transfigured us, no doubt, first, but it did possibly something to transform us. We must learn to love them as they did us, to honour them because they are ours, and it may be that, if they need transformation as much as we in our acuteness think that they do, our love and forbearance may be the commencement of it. You who have loving parents, do not wait till it is too late to give back a debt which is certainly owing to them. By-and-bye you, who perhaps are now discontented or smarting, will have a very different estimate of your parents ; your mind will recur to their earlier devotion to your well-being, and the memory of this will make you shed some of those tears that come from a very deep place, and which it is better, so much better, never to be obliged to shed.

Of course there are very difficult cases which arise sometimes, in which it is hard to see how the general principle can be applied. I will mention

* Cf. Dale on the "Ten Commandments," p. 119.

only one. In the case of grown-up children living with their parents difficulties often arise. It does not seem easy for some parents to understand that their children have grown up; just as it does not seem easy for some grown-up children to remember that their parents are their parents still. This much must be said; you do not honour your father and mother if, while still dependent on them, you claim a practical independence of their wishes. The filial relation demands as great a consideration of their wishes, and even, if you like, of their prejudices, as you would shew in the house of any friend at which you happened to be a guest. * If you claim only that amount of liberty you are probably claiming less than they would give you if they were wise, but at anyrate you will be quite certainly fulfilling your filial duty and keeping the Fifth Commandment.

III. The promise attached to this Commandment had a special and marked significance in a nation with a social organisation like the Jews. To disobey parents in a society where the national polity rested on the basis of the family, where the parents were in effect the magistrates as regards their own family, was a national offence, analogous to the offence of high treason. In the absence of those other complicated institutions which mark our Western civilisation, Jewish parents were charged with

* Cf. R. W. Dale on the "Ten Commandments," p. 131.

a practical despotism within their own family, which may have had its drawbacks, but which was a necessity in the existing state of things. They were the religious teachers, and therefore must be attended to, if the whole nation was not to fall back into heathenism and forfeit its unique position. The spirit of filial obedience really preserved the State from disorder and ruin ; without it, national existence would have been imperilled. This consideration gives the real meaning of the promise, "that thy days may be long in the land which the Lord thy God giveth thee." Of course this is not the case now. Disobedience to parents may still accidentally cause outside disturbance, but we cannot say that normally it would have the effect now which it had then. The Commandment now rests for its sanction on other grounds than its necessity for the permanence of the national life.

But there is a wider lesson conveyed in the promise appended to this Commandment which nations do well to mark. We may improve and reform many things; we may advance intellectually, morally, religiously, but reverence for the past and willingness to read its highest lessons may never safely be neglected by any nation which would have its days 'long in the land.' When we feel that we can despise the teachings of our ancestors and the lessons of their successes and the tragedies of their failures, we are on the high road to national ruin. To think

of the past with contempt, with nations as with individuals, is to sow the seeds of future despair.

The promise of the Fifth Commandment never loses its power; it always witnesses to the truth that, so far as a nation reverences its past and learns from it, to that extent it ensures its future.

I hope it is unnecessary for me to say that I am only asserting a general moral principle and not referring to any specific changes which may be in the air. We know nothing about them here. It is a great thing for a nation to have a history; every child should learn about the history of England—should be taught about God's dealings with us in days of old. In an age of rapid change, in an age when every institution is on its trial, it is well to remind ourselves of this. Because the claims of the past are sometimes pressed to an extent that would seem to throw a sanction over every abuse, because with some "we never did it before" is a sufficient ground for well nigh disowning the gift of reason; do not let any of us in a sudden reaction be ensnared into the error of supposing that we are the first wise generation, do not let us ignore the immense power of great traditions and noble history, do not let us forget that even the failures of the past have their lessons to teach us. A deep reverence for its lessons is quite consistent with striving patiently and quietly for a higher standard of national justice, unity, and freedom than we have hitherto gained; but a shallow

contempt for old and proved ways, a readiness to adopt any new scheme social or religious which is in the air, to reconstruct our creeds from the foundation and to frame brand new social organisations out of the cobweb theories of some crazy or conceited fanatic, is to impoverish our own ideas and to throw our influence on the side of national degeneration. We are the children of the past ; we can never study too closely the lessons of its wisdom and experience. We must honour our fathers and mothers of past generations even while we try to improve on their work, and just so far as we remember this we shall help to place the world in general and our own nation in particular on a higher level ; and shall dwell in the land, with all its glories and all its greatness, which the Lord our God has given us.

SERMON VII.

SECOND SUNDAY IN LENT, 1893.

“Thou shalt not kill.”—EXODUS xx. 13.

It has often been argued by persons of a somewhat literalist or rabbinical turn of mind, that the letter of this Commandment is so precise, so absolutely universal in its terms that it forbids the taking of human life under any circumstances whatever. The law is absolute, peremptory in its terms—“Thou shalt not kill”—under any circumstances whatever. Your country may be invaded by hostile armies, but you must not repel them: a foul and brutal murder may be committed, but the murderer must not be condemned to death. They would even tell the judge who sentences such an one that he repeats the crime which he would condemn; for the Commandment is absolute—“Thou shalt not kill.”

We have heard such propositions gravely argued in debating societies by men who evidently feel that their arguments are absolutely unanswerable. Somehow the literalist is always unanswerable till you look at the letter, and then you will almost always find that he is inconsistent, that his literalism

does not go far enough. In the case before us the literalist puts a limit on the Commandment, even while he seems to insist on the absolute nature of the precept. For in the bare letter of the Commandment there is no mention of taking human life; if we are to take it quite literally we must not only never kill a sheep for food or a snake for safety, we must drop our gun and let the tiger spring on us, nay, more, we must not even walk, for assuredly when we do, we kill something, insects or creeping things; and so we reduce the Commandment to an absolute absurdity.

Once concede the principle, once admit that there are any exceptions, and the literalist interpretation becomes impossible. You have ultimately to translate the naked prohibition, "Thou shalt not kill," into "Thou shalt not take human life without sufficient cause." And this is evidently the intention of the Commandment as God gave it to Moses. For the law itself prescribed death as the punishment for many sins, not only for murder, but for Sabbath-breaking, and for selling a Jew into slavery; while as regards war, the Jews were commanded again and again not only to go to war, but to destroy nations whose existence imperilled their own national welfare. The Jews had an army, a military organisation, constituted by God Himself; and whatever else may be said of many wars in modern times however bad their moral

influence, however terrible the anguish they inflict on widows and orphans, it can never be said that a righteous war in self-defence, or for the purpose of sheltering or delivering the oppressed, is against the law of God. What the police and the criminal law are to the evil passions and crimes of individuals, that war is and must be to the mad passions and infinitely more gigantic crimes of nations—a means, *i.e.*, of repression. As long as policemen and criminal courts are necessary (and we do not observe that those who condemn all wars are slow to avail themselves of either for their personal protection), so long will there be an occasional and sad necessity for war, when, *e.g.*, some scourge of humanity, like Bonaparte, arises to put nations on their self-defence.

But it is quite one thing to maintain that and another to say that every war is justified ; that there are not wars which, as far as the intention of their originators go, do break the Sixth Commandment. There have been conflicts waged in our own day, perhaps even by our own armies, for which it would be hard to find any justification ; but that is not really the question raised by the ultra-literalists ; it is whether war is ever justifiable, or whether we should at once disband our armies and turn our navy into a merchant fleet ; and certainly the Sixth Commandment does not tell us to do anything of the kind. No doubt the

fact of the existence of great armies and navies for attack or defence is a visible sign of the hold which evil passions still retain on the heart of Christendom ; but every prison and every assize tell the same story of evil passions and evil deeds ; and as it is not possible, while crime continues, to give up these, so on the larger scale it is not possible to forego the means of self-defence.

The principle which lies at the root of the Sixth Commandment is really that reverence for man which recognises his kinship with God, which perceives the Divine Image within him. The difference between killing a man and killing any other animal is that there is a sacredness about human life, which in the case of the lower animals does not exist. This is the justification of the death penalty for murder. Other offences we may punish by lesser sentences, but he who forgets that his fellow-man is more than a brute, he who ignores his kinship with God—he must be sent away to meet God, he has committed an offence which no human law can adequately punish, he must be sent and sent swiftly before the only tribunal that can really deal with his case. The death penalty is really the assertion of man's kinship with God, of his real greatness. "Whoso sheddeth man's blood by man shall his blood be shed, for in the image of God made He man." It ought to be said that the death penalty is no adequate punishment for murder ; but it does represent

in the strongest fashion a conviction about the greatness of human life and it sends the offender at once before the only tribunal that can really judge him. So much it is right to say in view of the discussions that are often thoughtlessly raised on the question. It is not here a question of deterrent, it is a question of how we shall mark our estimate of the reverence due to man and of the dignity of his nature ; and we can only do this in a real fashion by this one means of sending the offender to that higher tribunal, which can alone deal with such a case as his. And it is just this reverence for man as man, for man in his moral freedom, for man in his self-conscious determination, for man in view of his possible development, which, when once it lays hold of the heart and mind of a nation, makes murder impossible. The ultimate security for human life lies in reverence for human nature. Only so far as men feel the mysteriousness of human life, its separation from all other life ; only so far will that state of feeling arise among us that makes murder impossible. Directly that feeling dies away or begins to diminish, life becomes insecure, and murder is committed whenever passion becomes violent. It is so in barbarous countries, there men are killed without compunction ; it is so in those communities like San Francisco, where men come together merely for the sake of gain, where men live to gain money anyhow and to gamble as their only excitement. Wherever there is only respect

for dollars and no reverence for human life, murder is thought little of. So in countries where slavery exists and human nature is permanently dishonoured, not only is the life of the slave thought little of, but there is a general insecurity of life, crimes of violence are common. So it is among the rough classes in the most civilised states. When the humanising influences of religion and education make men feel that there is a greatness in man which they have not seen before, that to kill a man is to commit an awful crime against God, Whom in some sort every man represents; then there surrounds human life a wall of defence stronger than any penalty, however stern, can erect. Then the true basis of the Sixth Commandment is seen to be reverence for man, then it is seen that man must not be killed because he is akin to God, made in His image after His likeness.

And this reverence for man as God's child, as akin to the Father, we can all do much to encourage, by sternly checking within ourselves those base feelings of contempt or superciliousness which so often, alas, defile and dishonour the hearts of those who call themselves Christians. Whatever else a man may be, however poor, however uneducated, however stupid, however intellectually ill equipped, however silly and tiresome, he is always made in the image of God, he reflects in some way the Father. It is very hard sometimes to remember this: the super-

ficial aspects of human nature are often unattractive, sometimes repellent. It is very hard to have much respect for men whose one idea is to gamble, whose sole interest in the papers is the result of a race on which they have staked money; their society becomes intolerable to any educated person. Or when we come in contact with that sad type of motherhood, the pleasure-seeking, selfish, cynical young married woman, who, with countless opportunities for benefiting the lives of others, neglects her children, and only seems to care for dress or some frivolous amusement—it is hard to see in such even the remnants of the Divine Image. Divisions also make it difficult, and they are easily made. A superior intelligence, a very little advance in knowledge or in cultivation seems to put men on such different platforms. Difference of rank tends to division; even the power of expression creates divisions, which seem sometimes almost incapable of being bridged over. And yet in spite of all, deep down there is in every man, however darkened or deteriorated, that moral freedom and moral consciousness which are the great equalisers. In proportion as we recognise the presence of these things in all, we rise to hope for our race, as well as to that reverence for man himself, which surrounds every life with the most secure of all defences. For man's life is really only precious for the sake of what man is, so that even life itself may be freely surrendered, if its surrender

ensures the preservation of his inherent greatness. Do we not find that those who have been most strongly possessed by this sense of man's greatness, because he is made in the Image of God, have always been ready to surrender life for great and worthy reasons?

On the other hand, self-destruction prompted by mere weariness or by mere cowardice or unwillingness to face shame, is the greatest sin which a man can commit against himself. The suicide must have arrived at the deepest self-contempt, must have shorn himself of every recollection of his true self, before he can deal the fatal blow; and that, not because he surrenders life but because he surrenders self-respect, and proves himself a coward, too cowardly to struggle on. But the man who perishes in the pursuit of duty, the physician or nurse who remains by the couch of infection, or the philanthropist who wears himself out by his devotion to the relief of suffering mankind, or the martyr who sheds his blood for truth's sake, or the man who goes to certain death on behalf of his country, for such we have no honour high enough; the lips of all men confess that in losing their lives they keep them, that they are faithful to that trust, which is more sacred than life, to the true greatness of manhood. The man who puts an end to his life to save himself from trouble is unfaithful to his highest trust; the man who surrenders his life for great ends

shows that he is alive to the one great thing which is above life, viz., the image and the likeness of God within him.

Our Lord Himself has dealt with this Commandment in His characteristic fashion. He has said in effect that to give way to causeless anger is murder in its inchoate state. Repress causeless anger and murder becomes impossible. He has set back the struggle within man. The same principle which forbids murders will make both contempt and supercilious invective impossible. "Whosoever shall say 'Raca' shall be in danger of the Sanhedrim, and whosoever shall say 'thou fool,' shall be in danger of Gehenna." He takes the Jewish customs and their laws for purposes of illustration. According to His teaching, causeless anger merits the judgment of the lesser tribunal: contempt merits the judgment of a graver tribunal: while abuse deserves the greatest disgrace known to the Jewish Law, viz.: to be cast into Gehenna. There is implied in His words the necessity of reverence for man as man. Whatever man's sins, whatever his follies, whatever his infirmities, causeless anger or contempt or bitter abuse are not what we owe him. We may be angry with our brother, justly angry with him, but in the midst of our anger we shall remember that he is what he is, and that terms of bitter contempt and abuse only betray our forgetfulness of his real dignity and our own loss of self respect. As long as

we remember that, in the most essential thing of all, he is our equal, we shall respect him as we respect ourselves. We may blame his faults and castigate his follies ; we may reproach him for his unworthiness or condemn his deterioration ; but we shall still remember through it all, what he is ; we shall not forget Whose this Image and superscription is, and we shall render to the Divine within him the respect which is its due. And assuredly this recognition of his kinship to God will save us from words of contempt or from that personal abuse, which Christ condemns as the violation of the spirit of this Sixth Commandment.

The same consideration will make us long for his restoration and for reconciliation with him. If we have an adversary, if we have unwillingly wounded the feelings or cast a shadow over the lives of others, we shall not listen to the pride which forbids us to make any approaches towards reconciliation. We shall remember when we bring our gift to the Altar that it is our brother, the child of our Father, who has something against us, and we shall feel it no humiliation to leave our gift before the Altar, to seek reconciliation with our brother and only then to come before our common Father with clean hands and a pure heart.

And we shall do this exactly in proportion as we realise the Divine within our brother and reverence him accordingly. As long as we look upon him as

a rival in business or an opponent in politics or a social interloper, we shall no doubt use worse words of him than fool or apostate. But when we look deeper and recognise that he is in his essential self our brother, we shall find no difficulty in overlooking merely superficial divisions ; we shall claim our oneness with him in the deepest things of all, and for the sake of that oneness which no sin can destroy and no folly impair, we shall endeavour to be reconciled with him, to treat him as the brother that he really is.

The real underlying principle of the Sixth Commandment can only be recognised thus. It is meant to bring us back to the earliest truth about ourselves, the truth that can never be obliterated, that we and all men bear within us the Image of the Eternal God. That conscience which approves or terrifies is the likeness of the Righteousness of God ; the capacity for progress which makes us ever restless, ever eager, is the likeness of God's perfection ; our very anxiety about the future witnesses to the mark set upon us by the Eternity of God. " In the image of God created He him." His features are stamped upon every soul, however worn away by forgetfulness, however blurred by ill usage.

Live in the consciousness of that—of the Divine within you. The temptation of our age is to dwell on the lower affections of our nature, our animal emotions, our sensitiveness to change of circum-

stance, to variations of food, scenery and climate, our liability to hereditary influence. Only one thing can save us from the self disgust which all this often induces, viz., the living in the consciousness that whatever else there may be, there *is the Divine Image*, the God within you. The glory of that Presence within others will transfigure for you the meanest of your brethren, will make him interesting, will keep you from causeless anger, from biting contempt, from cruel sneers. The glory of that Presence within yourself will scare away the demons of vice, the foul thoughts, the unworthy imaginations; it will lift you above the infirmities of your nature, the weak will, the coward heart, the faltering mind; it will teach you to respect yourself because you will forget *yourself* in the unceasing recognition of that Divine Presence, the Image of God, which you will feel to be your only true self.

SERMON VIII.

THIRD SUNDAY IN LENT, 1893.

“Thou shalt not commit adultery.”—EXODUS xx. 14.

THE last Commandment which we were considering proclaimed the sanctity of human life, taught us that human life, however misused, is in God's eyes a sacred thing which He Himself protects. The Seventh Commandment proclaims the sanctity of man's body, the dignity and sacredness of human nature. Among the Jews it was protected by a penalty as severe as that which defended human life; death was the penalty of adultery. The sanctity of man's nature is thus proclaimed by God to be as important a principle as the inviolability of his life. To tamper with it in yourself or in others is profanation; to hold it cheap is to disparage the Divine idea, of which it is a symbol. “He that despiseth, despiseth not man but God.” To commit adultery is to “despise God.”

Let us see how this Commandment affects

1. All persons married or unmarried.
2. Those in the married state.

1. The sacredness of human nature—its holiness—is the principle proclaimed to the Jews by the Seventh Commandment. It goes without saying that for us Christians this principle is deepened and accentuated immensely by Christianity. When Christ took our nature and became bone of our bone and flesh of our flesh, was made of one flesh with us; when He sent His Holy Spirit to dwell in us to make our bodies His Temple; when He instituted His Holy Sacrament that His Body and Blood might dwell in us and we in Him, that our 'sinful bodies might be made clean by His Body,' then was seen plainly the Divine idea which underlay that stern penalty which in old days attended any breaking of the Seventh Commandment. The great Apostle only draws out the real significance of what had been dimly understood before, when, after proclaiming the Christian's body to be holy—a temple of the Holy Spirit—he adds, "If any man defile the temple of God him shall God destroy."

This is the root principle on which all else depends. The man or woman who realises it, not merely keeps from actual sin, from sins against purity; they struggle to keep from dishonouring thoughts of others, they sternly repress degrading images within the heart; they respect and reverence themselves and others too much to willingly permit them. It is not too much to say that the

real struggle in this matter is one which is altogether inward in its essence; that whatever brings shame in thought is a defeat; that without any word or act coming out, the idea of purity is realised or lost sight of within, and that when it is lost sight of, potential ruin is there already; whenever opportunity comes, the actual fall follows. The conflict is really waged, the battle is won or lost *within*. The will controls the mind, and the mind governs the body in this matter, and if the will only can be kept true, all else follows.

From temptation there is only one safety, and that is in flight. If only when temptation comes people will fly from it, if only they will not go where they find it, the victory is practically won. Flight is here no cowardice; in it lies the one true and only real safety. Carry out the principle consistently. Give up any friend who does not respect his or her nature, who does not show by word and action that he reverences his nature. There is no safety for you with them; you may be carried into the vilest things unless you keep away from an influence which wars with self-respect.

Above all, we have to learn to control our affections, to love where we choose and to withhold our love where we ought. The picture of uncontrollable affections—often set before us by writers of unwholesome fiction—conveys an untrue impression. There may be a time when affection does become

uncontrollable, but the battle is waged before then, and from an earlier want of self-control comes the misery of defeat. "Keep thy heart diligently," says the wise man, "for out of it are all the issues of life." The unkept heart loses its pure, sweet power of love, and changes from an angel which guides into the demon that destroys. Self-restraint in affection, watchfulness whether you are loving people in the right way or not, flight from all temptation of companions, books, places, from all things which cause you to stumble, above all, frequent bracing of will by earnest prayer and by considering St Paul's words about the sacredness of our bodies—this is well-worn advice, but it can hardly be given too earnestly. There are dangers all around us; there are still evil men and women who hover round and try to entrap the innocent and unwary. There are fanatical agitators who are bent on exposing every scandal in the press and elsewhere, and who are fatally spreading the mischief which they profess to wish to cure. They minister to a diseased curiosity; they are all the more dangerous enemies of purity because they come in the disguise of friends. The denunciation of vileness is often the trade of the secretly vile. The "pure in heart" do not hold up offenders against purity to shame on every occasion; they feel the danger of mere denunciation. Some of us may have known cases in which such denuncia-

tions have been only a too easily assumed cloak for sins secretly indulged. There is a state of villainess hard for many of us to conceive of, that would sooner hear this sin denounced than not spoken of. To paint the beauty, the loveliness, the strength of purity as Ruskin and Tennyson have done, is to do more to keep men and women pure than all the denouncers and exposers of shameful things can ever effect by their methods.

It is impossible here and now to preach to the fallen; the only task I set myself is to warn. "Let him that thinketh he standeth take heed lest he fall," is a necessary caution for us all, and most of all, perhaps, for those who are least conscious of its necessity.

There is no sin so degrading as the one which under the guise of affection forgets this reverence for human nature; none so quickly eats out the good in man or woman; none makes them so morally infectious; no enemy is so hard to drive out as this when once it has gained its footing. "This kind goeth not out but by prayer and fasting."

There is such danger in the fact that the highest and holiest feelings of our nature are so near the worst, that the barrier between intense sympathy and sensuality is so easily destroyed. Moreover, the temptation to knowledge is so alluring, and yet such bitter shame and self-reproach are the consequences of yielding to it. The apples of

Sodom are beautiful to look upon, but their taste in the mouth is as the taste of ashes.

Reverence then your bodies, reverence the bodies of others; if you have sinned in any way, the starting point for repentance is to learn reverence for your body. It is not your own; it is the Holy Spirit's Temple. Remember that always, and you will have a peace and a freedom for which others sigh in vain.

2. I pass on to consider the Commandment as it affects those in the married state.

Marriage as it is put before us in the New Testament is undoubtedly Sacramental in character. The Church of England, in its anxiety to preserve the unique position for Baptism and Holy Communion, has not called it a Sacrament, but to those who, like myself, believe in the Sacramental principle as the only ground of real religion, and who see not only seven but seven hundred Sacraments in man and nature all around us—to us the profoundly Sacramental nature of marriage seems its chief distinction. It is at once deeply mysterious and profoundly symbolical; a holy state, and yet the region of the most ordinary affections and the most simple delights. It means something very wonderful, and yet it takes the simplest love and consecrates and blesses it. No wonder St Paul's great and reverent mind, after discoursing on the duties of the married state, stops awestruck at the

mystery behind it. 'This is a great mystery,' he cries out—'this worship of woman by man—this wonderful consecrating bond which makes of two one, which binds them into the same unity as Christ has established between Himself and the Church.'

Profoundly Sacramental then marriage is; it typifies heavenly things, it transfigures what it takes and finds, it links us with unknown unions of which it is the earthly pattern; and yet it touches human nature so closely everywhere in its ways and methods, demanding self-sacrifice, subduing wilfulness, developing tenderness, teaching the ultimate secret of God that no man can really live to himself; so far-reaching in its educational power, unfolding within such ordinary men and women that perfect self-sacrificing love which is the crown of God's perfections; beautiful in cottages as in palaces; developing virtues which would otherwise have remained dormant, bringing out fatherly restraint and motherly tenderness, which are the highest copies on earth of the pattern in the heavens, of the strength and tenderness of God.

If you would have purity in the land you must maintain a noble ideal of marriage; you must assert that, in itself, it is the carrying out on earth of a Divine idea, that sin against it is sin against that idea, is a repudiation of it. Treat it as a contract which may be dissolved and re-made with some one else,

and you speedily find yourself in low moral regions with a debased tone. The harm which the establishment of the Divorce Court has done, especially in the upper classes of society, is simply incalculable. There are cases, no doubt, in which relief from the marriage bond must be granted, because they transcend the possibilities of endurance; but when the law made marriage dissoluble in such a way as to make re-marriage possible, the deadliest blow was dealt at morality, at the sacredness of home life. In America it has been carried to disastrous lengths. One who was known to some of us as the American Minister here has summed up its results in these words, "The whole business is a disgrace to our country, and a standing menace to social order." And among ourselves facility of divorce has led insensibly to lightly considered marriages, and those lightly considered marriages have lowered the whole tone of family life in certain sections of society.

Happily in England the family life of the great middle class is, as a rule, exceptionally pure and high, and as long as marriage is presented on its ideal side there, we shall have pure homes and decent living. But nothing is clearer from history than that a low view of marriage and a low standard of married faithfulness means ruin to those who adopt it.

And if nothing so contributes to ruin, social and individual, as a low view of marriage; so the

highest view is at once most ennobling in its effects on those who hold it for themselves and on all around.

Look at it in this way, not only at its loftiness as an ideal, but also at its effects. Think how often marriage of this kind means new birth to people who enter it rightly. Look at the listless women who live only to dress, and see what a marriage of real affection makes of them. See how it takes young men and makes out of very ordinary clay really brave, self-devoted, self-sacrificing heroes. See how the love of wife and child, like an alchemy, draws out of men unsuspected virtues and dormant greatness. Whence these wonderful results? Because such men and women have lost their lives, and the Master's words are verified in them, "He who loses his life shall find it." This great saying is vindicated in every man who surrenders his life in self-sacrificing affection, and through self-surrender becomes conscious of himself, and discovers within himself unsuspected capacities and powers. We often laugh at the idealisations of young lovers; perhaps we have much more reason to envy them. It may be that their love has done for them what our cold judgments could not do for us, has made them clear-sighted enough to see not only the actual virtues but the latent possibilities of virtues in each other. This insight it is which fills those sunny hours with so strange a joy. It is the finding of

ideal beauties in another; it is the consciousness that another has found in oneself not the self one knows but a better, truer, higher self, a self that ought to be and will be our whole self. Ah, some hard old cynic growls, "Wait a bit and see them, these are the dreams, the follies of youth." No doubt there may be subsequent failures, but after all, which is the deepest, truest estimate of a man, that which judges him like a joint of meat by his actual imperfections and failures, or that of the faith which is insight, and which sees through all the imperfections and grasps at the bottom the Divine idea of the man or woman—the strength, the truth, the devotion which are possible to him? Which I ask is God's view—that which looks on the failures of men, or that which looks on the possibilities within him? Surely it may well be that lovers' dreams prove truer in the long run than the verdict of a shrewd and cynical experience. Do not then let us laugh at love's dream, do not let us call it a folly; let us think only that the longer it lasts the better for both. The romance and poetry of courtship too often soon disappear; but it is still true that only in the glory and glow of that youthful affection is the true idea of marriage to be found. The intensity of the love which saw those early visions must remain, if ever the ideal of marriage is to be fulfilled.

No, let us not smile, let us rather see in any real

self-devotion, even if its presentation be a little overstrained, let us see something to envy and to emulate. After all, the true protection against the perils aimed at by this Commandment is to be found in dwelling on the highest and most noble ideals of marriage which we can find, and in endeavouring to raise the general tone and to spread great thoughts about it.

* One of the chief characteristics of the Teutonic nations is that they have always, by noble and affectionate family life, borne witness to the greatness of purity. When we say that, of course we have to allow for a large margin of signal and obvious exceptions; we do not forget them when we say that public opinion among those nations has a special esteem and admiration for this virtue, and that the vices and faults which it specially dislikes are their opposite; that the virtues connected with purity have been congenial to the English and German nations; that they have been cherished in countless households which with all their other imperfections have been schools of goodness in its strongest forms, shrines of love and holiness and peace. No greater trust has been handed down to us than our home life, for nothing has more powerfully affected the development of character in our race. We do not always live up to all that it involves, but we always honour it;

* Cf. Dean Church on "Christianity and the Teutonic Races."

we always acknowledge it as our only allowable standard. Home is a Teutonic thing in word and deed ; the life of home has been the great delight, the "great social achievement" of our race, its refuge from storms and darkness without, its compensation for the lack of that social brilliancy which characterises the Latin races. Reverence for family life, a high sense of its duties, a keen relish for its pleasures, this has been the ennobling element in the Teutonic races. The decay and absence of this taste for the quiet and unexcited life of home is a dangerous symptom wherever it appears ; for, as has been said, "if ever home life with its sanctities, its simplicity, its calm and deep joys and sorrows ceases to have its charm for us in England, the greatest catastrophe in English history will not be far off." Alas, that there are some in high places of influence and example who, by destroying it, are doing their best to ruin their country ; and that with scarcely a protest raised against them. As to the beauty of English home life there is still a general agreement ; but the point to be remembered is, that we cannot have the flower and the fruit if we destroy the root : we cannot cherish the beauty of home life, and continue to view with complacency that which cuts at its very root. The increasing frequency of Divorce, the hideous mockery of these quasi-remarriages which defile our churches and make the marriage service a

mockery, are undermining slowly but surely our best traditions. We must make our protest in order to maintain by our influence and example a noble ideal for our children. We have to be faithful to the trust of a most sacred tradition ; and the thing that concerns us most at the present time as a nation is to see that we do not despise our birthright, that we are not so thoughtless, so base as to cast away that sacred tradition of pure English homes, which we may lose even while we admire it, but which, once lost, we can never recover.

SERMON IX.

FOURTH SUNDAY IN LENT, 1893.

“Thou shalt not steal.”—EXODUS xx. 15.

THERE can be no question raised about the kind of principle on which this Commandment rests. It is the Divine recognition of the institution of property. It lays down broadly that those social arrangements by which a man claims certain things as his own, and is supported by the law in his claim, are according to the Will of God, and that to endeavour to deprive him of them by force or by fraud is to break God's law. It does not of course lend its sanction to all and every such arrangement that has ever been made; there may have been arrangements which involved robbery at the outset and which ought to be set aside; but it asserts that there is an ultimate principle of possession which God Himself recognises and protects, and that to interfere with it is not only to commit an offence against the law of the land but to commit a sin against God.

Some of you will perhaps be inclined to think it superfluous to assert this principle and to enter into the reasons for its justification before such a

congregation as this. One might conceive probably of assemblies to which such arguments might be more usefully addressed, even if they were less patiently listened to. But there are reasons which, I trust, may appear, why it is well for us to look at the moral reasons and grounds of these laws, which some of us may have other reasons, connected with our personal interests, for wishing to maintain.

Among such reasons, not the least is that no investigation of the kind can well leave us without that deepened sense of responsibility both for the use of what is our own and for the means which we use in acquiring what we wish to make our own, which it is often hard for those, whose chief concern it sometimes is to defend what they have, to keep.

The institution of property is not always easy at first sight to defend. Those who consider themselves bound by the Divine law will of course not cease to maintain that property is holy because of the difficulties which arise in details, as apparent consequences of that institution. But there are difficulties in the consequences of this principle, which sometimes seem to cast a doubt upon the wisdom of the Divine sanction; and it is always better to face these difficulties than to leave them to rankle or to allow them to gather force by unchallenged repetition. We will look first at the difficulties and then at the answer to them.

1. The difficulties connected with property are

seen in their strongest light in the moral effects which are often produced by it on those who can call little or nothing their own, and scarcely less perhaps on those who, having something of their own, feel impelled to defend what they have as the most sacred of all duties.

The records of police courts and of criminal cases at the Assizes seem to furnish a large number of cases of offences against property, offences which as a rule seem to be punished with far greater severity than offences against the person; and I suppose that the justification pleaded for this (which seems so demoralising to the ordinary mind), would be said to lie in their greater frequency. Property appears to increase and aggravate crime more than anything else. It produces envy, hatred, covetousness, dishonesty, fierce and angry railing, discontent, which are amongst the worst faults to which human nature is liable. It is not too much to say that the sight of other's possessions gives rise to feelings which are the cause of much crime and much secret wrong doing. Many of us are sheltered perhaps even from the knowledge of the existence of such feelings. Their outward expression is kept in check by the police. Sometimes when we come face to face with them as they actually exist, we are startled and horrified, almost inclined to wish that there were no such thing as property, so

grievous seem to be its results on others ; and even if we are not carried to such lengths, yet the tremendous inequalities of the distribution of wealth drive us to seek all kinds of remedies. Hundreds of thousands of men in London are hardly able to obtain the bare necessities of existence ; a few thousands live in splendour and luxury. One man lives in a house a great deal too large for his wants, which perhaps is shut up for nine months in the year, while two or three hundred yards away there are a hundred thousand people living in dismal courts and narrow streets, in houses where decency is impossible and comfort undreamt of.

The selfishness of possession, in the case of open spaces in crowded neighbourhoods, is another difficulty. If we have not a clear vision of consequences or an interest in maintaining things as they are, we cannot help having doubts about it. 'Would it not be better to equalise, to divide everything up ; and then when the old inequalities reappeared, as they might reappear, to divide up again ?' 'Would not the world become a better place, would not much of the sin and wretchedness, the discontent, the envy, the bitter hatred of the world, disappear if that were done ?' 'Would it not be possible to derive a far higher general level of comfort at the expense of the few who would after all not starve ?' That is what every one, who feels much, has some time or other thought ;

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it is the kind of remedy which suggests itself to the young, to the generous and to the enthusiastic as well as to the very miserable. And the worst thing that can happen to anyone is to refuse to entertain questions about such difficulties, merely because they are unwelcome and might involve personal discomfort.

There are, however, solid reasons for not assenting to them which have no suspicion of selfishness about them. For in the first place security of property insures the continuance of production. Without it, the earth would not be cultivated as it is. Take away possession, and you take away the motive power of cultivation, and if cultivation were to cease we should have to revert to the spontaneous production of the soil and to the food of the savage. We can easily see for ourselves how that which belongs to everybody seldom has a chance of arriving at maturity. *As has been shrewdly said, "a cherry tree in a hedge row, nuts in a wood," to which one might add, a strawberry bed in a public garden, "are seldom of much profit to any one, because no one will wait for the proper season to gather them. Corn if it were sown would never ripen, lambs and calves would never become sheep and cows if they belonged to nobody, because the first person that met them would reflect that he had better take them himself than leave them for another."

* Dale on the "Ten Commandments."

The institution of property unquestionably then stimulates production, and causes innumerable works to be commenced and completed which would otherwise be left undone. If it were abolished and everything divided up, the material wealth of the world would almost disappear, and the poorest and most wretched would sink to even a lower level than they do at present. Even the savage would sit idle in his hut, if the game he hunted were not his own; so the baker would not bake bread, or the builder build houses, unless their title to possession was secure. The well-being of the whole community really depends on the security of property, because that alone gives the necessary stimulus to production. Of course the question of public or private ownership is not touched by this Commandment, and therefore I pass it by. The only point is, that ownership of some kind is an absolute necessity if production is to continue. The Eighth Commandment has a double sanction; it is founded not only on the Divine law but also on the results of human experiences.

2. Property then is holy, and its sacredness, as asserted by Divine law, is conducive to human welfare. The Jewish Church says so, the Christian Church has always ratified the assertion. But the Christian Church does not and dare not end by saying that. The Jewish law said that the sanctity of property was preserved by the payment

of tithes ; the Christian Church must say something of the kind. In proportion as she ends by saying baldly that property is holy, in proportion as she has only blessed the rights of property, she has been powerless to influence those who possess, or to satisfy the instincts of justice in those who do not. The Church is bound to witness to another truth, viz., that there is involved in all property the obligation to recognise a common Father, a common Redeemer, a common humanity ; and that these are not vague abstractions to be assented to and then dismissed, but that they are eternal, primary bonds on which all other things depend ; * “that they are not satisfied by an occasional act of homage, but that all our doings must bear witness to them.” The Church proclaims by her existence the oneness of mankind in Christ and the obligation of mutual service ; she blesses property, but it is property held upon this tenure—the tenure of mutual obligation. Here has been sometimes the weakness of her witness ; here she has failed to speak out. She has given her best assistance to those who possess and who could well protect themselves, but she has not witnessed consistently to that brotherhood of mankind which, if realised, would have made such protection unnecessary. Failing in this duty she has become powerless in face of wild schemes. “She can

* F. D. Maurice on the “Ten Commandments.”

scarcely make herself heard against schemes for reducing everything to a common state, for establishing a fellowship based on mutual selfishness because she has not believed in the unity of members in One Head." If we understood—if it was a real thing to us all alike, that we were children of one Father, and that no one who possessed anything must call it "his own" in a selfish fashion, if we had a disposition to share advantages and to count every means of ministering to others a privilege, we should not have to complain as we do now, that the poor who heard our Master gladly, do not, for the most part, care to listen to us at all. The Church of England at this hour is supposed by great masses of our countrymen to be "against the working men." We are exhorted continually by those in authority to build more churches. Some of us, who do not live up in balloons but here on this earth, humbly venture to think it would work better if more pains were taken to see that clergy were appointed who would fill some of those that are built, and which are often kept empty by the alienation of those who should fill them. The reason for that alienation is, I believe, most of all a want of sympathy with the masses on the part of those who minister in them. At any rate the alienation is one which every effort which we make to show that we do recognise the eternal bonds of Creation, Redemption and Humanity, as

lying deeper than the question of comparative rank and wealth, would do very much to abolish. When we enter into the spirit of that earliest Christian enthusiasm, when 'every man said that nothing he possessed was his own,' and can direct our enthusiasm in the wisest way, and in safe directions, we are doing more to gain the confidence of those who often think of us as their natural foes than by any amount of religious propaganda. The Christ must come in these days not as a Name nor as a far-off dream, but He must come to man through man, through men who have the Christian spirit; otherwise He will never be heard or recognised by the great mass of those who have seen in many representations of Him "no beauty that they should desire Him."

Treated in this fashion as a trust, property becomes an instrument of great power; and it is impossible not to insist that it is just in these directions that the moralizing effect of property makes itself felt. Nothing acts upon you more quickly than the way in which you treat and look upon and use what you have, and that not in one way but in twenty ways. Are you generous or are you selfish? Are you straight or are you dishonest? Are you self-restrained or are you extravagant and careless? Are you indolent or are you industrious? This single institution of property gives the means of testing you in all these points. Again, how do you

get what you have? Men are under a constant temptation to steal, not in coarse ways but in refined ones. To employ trust monies in illegitimate fashions, to get possession of what belongs to others by fraudulent prospectuses, or by giving them what you know to be of less value than they think it is,—these are to all intents and purposes methods of stealing, possibly more refined than robbing tills or picking pockets, but just as culpable and surely just as deteriorating. Among the surest tests of character are the methods of acquiring and using wealth. If a man gets it by honest labour, if he resists every temptation to get it illegitimately, then the love of honesty is deepened within him, the meaner side of his nature is repressed. In such fashions we can make “friends of the mammon of unrighteousness;” by honesty in acquisition and also by self-restraint in expenditure; by industry in our calling, and above all by a deep recognition that what we have is entrusted to us by God, that it is not our own in the deepest sense, and that in the use of it we should remember both God’s glory and him whom God has entrusted to our pity and our care, as well as those causes which are identified with His service.

In the actual constitution of society, it always must be that property will be distributed most unequally. There are ways and schemes for forcibly redressing these inequalities, which this is not the place to discuss; but generally one may say that

those of them which do not seem to fail of justice seem to be unpractical, and those which are practical seem to fail of justice. We have to appeal to the higher feelings in order to secure the fairer distribution of advantages ; we have to put before men the blessedness of giving, the moral beauty not only of the relief of suffering and poverty, but of service in any shape or form in which we can render it. There is no more definite claim upon us, as Christians, than to help the various causes round us. We must not call it charity ; it is justice. God demanded of the Jews a tenth of their property for sacred purposes, just as He demanded a seventh of their time free from the intrusion of secular business. The Sabbath has passed away as a restrictive ordinance of obligation, yet we all recognise the spiritual value of Sunday and its moral value as a day of rest ; the Sabbath has reappeared in a higher and nobler form, in the free consecration of Sunday to the worship of God and the cultivation of our higher nature. So, no doubt, the old law which demanded tithes is no longer obligatory, but it ought to find its counterpart in the free gifts of the willing heart ; which will certainly find, in its definiteness, at any rate a suggestion of dedicating some distinct portion of its means to God's service. If there were any revival of Judaism which we should desire to prevail, it would be the practice of paying tithes. Too often our rule seems to be to give what we can

spare ; we offer to God at our Sunday worship something which we might give a railway porter for some trifling service, or something less even than the fare which perhaps we pay to the cabman who drives us to church. As long as we give merely what we can spare, it will seem to be very little. The claims of dress and amusement, or of travel and buying books, will seem to leave very little margin ; and what we can spare comes to mean what we shall never miss. Of course we may, some of us, give large sums elsewhere—I sincerely hope we do—but in the case of the great majority of those who worship here it would be hard to establish any ratio between their incomes and their yearly subscriptions to the Parish Charities. If you look through the book of our accounts and try to do the sum you will soon give it up in despair. Five or even ten pounds a year out of an income of thousands is what men give when they give what they can spare, *i.e.*, what they think may be left after satisfying every possible claim of self-indulgence. The only way in which to keep the spirit of the Eighth Commandment, the only way not to steal from God, is to give some definite proportion of one's income to good works, and then to divide it among what we conceive to be the most deserving objects. Only let us be sure that when we do this, we give something which will not cover us with shame when we see it set over against all the money which we have spent on our-

selves, on what we can only call our luxuries and not our necessities.

When I read the piteous appeals which come to me week by week for helping the work of the Church—to many of which I am obliged to turn a deaf ear—it makes one's heart ache to think of the money thoughtlessly and childishly squandered, night after night, all round us, not in simple and kindly hospitality, but in mere display and luxury, with no apparent motive but to outbid someone else. There is a real solid happiness, a solid satisfaction, in an attempt to regulate one's expenditure. It makes life sweet and clean; it redeems it from the sordid, the vulgar, the meaner elements that often defile it, even in our high civilisation. "Give alms of your goods and behold all things are clean unto you," is the Divine command which knows no exceptions and admits of no evasions. May God help us now and always to sanctify all we have, in the only way in which we really can, by acting upon it.

SERMON X.

FIFTH SUNDAY IN LENT, 1893.

“Thou shalt not bear false witness against thy neighbour.”—
EXODUS xx. 16.

THIS Commandment is aimed not so much at untruthfulness and lying generally as against untruthfulness and lying of a particular kind, viz., of the kind which affects the character of others. It forbids giving false testimony in the courts of justice: it is aimed in its rough letter at that perjury which we are told is so lamentably on the increase in the courts of law, and especially in that one court which is every day, in many other ways, doing the deadliest mischief to our national life and morals. The perjurer, the false swearer, breaks the Ninth Commandment: his is an offence which all men condemn. To equivocate, to conceal in a law court what is essential for the due execution of justice, is only a less crime than to make an absolutely false statement there, it is a crime not only against men but against Him, from Whom judges derive their power to judge. Those who lie in a court of justice lie not unto men but unto God. The judge is a minister of God, the jury for the time being are ministers of God; and

if by false witness any man attempts either to turn aside penalties from the criminal or to involve the innocent in undeserved condemnation, if he goes one iota in his evidence beyond what he knows, and swears that he knows what he only thinks or infers to be the case, then he is attempting to defeat the Divine Government of the world, to deceive not only God's representatives in the administration of the law, but the God Whom he must one day meet face to face.

But that is not all. * 'There is another court of justice which sits informally every day and every hour ;' a court of which we are all members, and in that court the Ninth Commandment is broken only too often. That court is the tribunal of public opinion which, however varied it may be in its composition, is always in some shape trying each one of us. Its composition is varied indefinitely : for the business man it is composed of those with whom he does business : for some of us it may be limited to a circle little wider than our own family : for others who occupy a larger space in the public eye, for lawyers or statesmen, or public men of any kind, for clergymen and doctors it is composed of a wider and less cohesive section of the public. It sits not only in London, but in every country town, in every village ; it tries cases, and pronounces judgment ; it condemns or absolves every day. Its

* Cf. Dale on the "Ninth Commandment."

proceedings are often very irregular and its decisions are often very inconsistent, but those decisions do make or mar the peace of mind of thousands. We can never hope, nor ought any of us to wish, to interrupt its sittings, to cause it to abstain from considering our cases. Its right to decide for or against us is no doubt strictly limited by its knowledge of the actual facts of any case and by its acquaintance with our actual proceedings; its judgments are often based on the most insufficient evidence; now and then it may and does become our duty to disregard them, but even if we are compelled to do so, we ought not to wish to stop them; they often protect us from worse evils. For though the sentences of this tribunal may often be unjust, they yet have a certain value; for they are a protest against that worst state of all, which is reached when any society becomes absolutely indifferent to the good or evil deeds of its members.

Within its limits, then, public opinion has its distinct value, the public opinion of our set or our class or our society about us ought to claim a certain respect from us. The man who defies it may be a hero and a saint—sometimes he is—but he may be a fool or a fanatic, or even a knave, and it is not by any means improbable that he will be either one or the other.

But the one thing which every man, from the king on the throne down to the common hangman,

has a right to demand is that no false witness shall be borne against him before that tribunal which is daily trying him, that there shall be no malice and no carelessness in the evidence given against him. That is the one demand which everyone, man of business or physician, peer or peasant, statesman or clergyman, has a right to make, that nothing shall be spoken falsely against him out of malice or out of carelessness. If that be granted, no man of sense will object to the tribunal or regard its decisions with anything but respect. He may not always see his way to conform to them, but he will feel the truth of the saying that no man is a judge in his own case; and if he has any modesty he will respect every general judgment, that is based on acquaintance with the real facts, as more likely to be true than his own individual opinion about his conduct. But then he has a right—everyone in public or private life has a right—to demand that the facts shall be known by all who aspire to compose the court on any occasion; and that is where the Ninth Commandment comes in. That demand is set at naught every day and every hour, and in consequence much misery and wrong ensues. For the penalties inflicted by that court are awful; it does not condemn to penal servitude or give you over to the hangman, but it destroys peace of heart, it blights the happiness of homes, it smites cruelly at reputations, it robs men of friends, it blasts all

the joys of life—except those that arise from conscious innocence and the sense of the peace of God within.

And we may, when in any case we elect to sit on that tribunal—we may be doing this diabolical work, we may be making the righteous sad, we may be poisoning another's peace by uttering unjust suspicions, we may be wounding and hurting those who have done nothing to deserve it, because we have not remembered that there is such a thing as perjury outside law courts, and that every man or woman who forms conclusions in malice, or says that of another which is untrue, is a perjured person, bears false witness against his neighbour, breaks the Law of God, sins against the Ninth Commandment. For we are bound to know that those things which we say of others are true; we are also bound not to accept the statements which are made to us, unless the proof be sufficient. Mere surmise, mere suspicion, mere gossip, mere argument from a particular instance to a universal conclusion we are bound to distrust, to discredit, to refuse to repeat or to be influenced by. Otherwise we are doing our best to create and maintain a polluted atmosphere in the court of public opinion, which is certain to produce falsehood and injustice.

We cannot say this too strongly, in the face of the influences which surround us. Doubtless there

is less vile innuendo now in our common talk than when Sheridan wrote his plays, yet Sir Benjamin Backbite may still be met in our drawing-rooms and at our social gatherings. And there is in our age much recklessness of statement. Often in the case of a man opposed to us in politics we discover, or affect to discover, a want of principle, which probably only arises from the fact that he differs from us. There is something very morally deteriorating in not being able to see two sides to a question and in the common inability not to think that everyone must be a criminal or a villain who differs from you. The public press does much harm in this way; its writers are anonymous and often indulge in personalities which would be impossible without that shelter. We live in times when, on political and religious questions, the greatest recklessness of statement is widely indulged in. It is rather the surprising exception when we find a man who can state a case fairly and justly as against his opponents. And the effect of exaggeration—of big words and sounding threats is to make public men indifferent to public opinion. We are not angry, when we ought to be, at misstatements: we only smile and say that it is just like our political or religious opponents—whatever they may be called.

We, who call ourselves Christians, are bound to protest against this. It is not a right spirit. So

far as a man is filled with Christ's Spirit, he will abstain from scornful indifference to the opinions of other men, he will recognise in all men the presence of a light which, however darkened, is not wholly extinguished. God has not given to either political party or to any religious section a monopoly of His gifts. And we must not say that it does not matter that such things should be said: it does matter. Slander always matters in one way; it always injures the slanderer. And moreover God by this Commandment shows that there is importance to be attached to the moral judgments of men about each other. After forbidding them to kill, to commit adultery or to steal, he adds the no less necessary injunction not to bear false witness. The Commandment is the proof that the judgments of mankind have a certain part to play in the moral life of others, and that it is the greatest possible sin to let falsehood or malice or recklessness enter into those judgments. This rule applies to public questions as well as to matters of personal conduct. A right and pure public opinion on national questions is of the greatest possible importance, and everyone of us has something to do in helping to form one. If we try to poison the public mind by false accusation, by unfair innuendo against those who differ from us, we are trying to obtain a judgment from the tribunal of national opinion by bearing false witness. We

are seeming perhaps to serve our party, but we are pushing public life down to a lower level as our share of affecting it. "If you throw plenty of mud some of it is sure to stick" it is said, and that is quite true; though it is also true that a good deal must inevitably return ultimately to yourself, like the boomerang of a savage. But it would be useless to deny that the mud-thrower may succeed in creating for a time a false opinion.

More deadly still are the results of false witness when you view it in reference to private life. If poisoned weapons in political and ecclesiastical warfare are deadly and self-deteriorating, if it is odious and wicked to slander a dissenter because he is a dissenter, or a political opponent because he disagrees with you—what shall we say of the circulation of private scandal?

After all, the tribunal of public opinion does discount heavily statements made against political or ecclesiastical opponents, but the circulation of private scandal does not display often the same reason for interested motives, and it is therefore accepted more readily. The reputation of individuals—their usefulness as well as their peace of mind—is often at the mercy of some poor, weak compound of treachery and malice who insinuates a lie, which he or she dare not utter openly.

Of course this is more obviously the case in a country town or village than in the great world of

London, where people, who live next door, often do not know each other by sight. Except in small sets in London no media for the circulation of general gossip exist; though in these small sets much mischief is done. London doubtless has its drawbacks in the way of physical atmosphere; but you live your life less trammelled by gossip and slander here than anywhere else; the very place seems to inspire larger interests than personalities. Nevertheless in some parishes, though we hope not here, there is much ecclesiastical gossip of the worst kind. And the venom of it, however limited its range, gives untold pain.

At this hour the keen and agonizing sufferings of sensitive people are appealing mutely to the only court of final appeal, the judgment of God, against the judgments of the tribunal of public opinion, which has listened to malicious and careless gossip; to this hour there is the wreckage strewn all round us which slander has wrought: there are broken friendships, lives severed that once were one—and that too brought about not by wilful lies but by the idlest and most thoughtless misrepresentation. If one once sees the misery which slander has the power to inflict on certain natures, one is certain that there is no cruelty so terrible as the cruelty of the thoughtless gossip.

Almost the finest sermons of the century in my humble judgment are those of the late Mr Robert-

son of Brighton; they are so discriminating, so searching; above all, so Christian in tone and spirit. Did you ever notice in reading them the almost bitterness, the refined yet terrible severity of the denunciation of the slanderer, through whose poison he had so obviously suffered. Those who have not suffered from anything of the kind, whose only feeling is that people's judgments of them are too generous, can yet feel an indignation, that is at times almost unendurable, that noble natures like his should have met with such a treatment. It shows the power of the unjust sentences of this court in the most lurid light, if they could so move a man of his pure life, his generous self-devotion, his devotion to truth.

Many of us must have known of similar instances in our own experience, where those who seem to deserve it least have had the hardest measure dealt to them, *e.g.*, those who, being shy and reserved, cannot defend themselves. One cannot help at times feeling a burning indignation at the terrible trade of the calumniator, the vile profession of the scandal monger, the gossip. There are houses that make one shudder when one passes the very door, because they are associated with the vile insinuations and petty malice, and all the horrible ways of the professional female gossip.

But the question comes—what of ourselves? “Thou that judgest another judgest thou not thyself?”

1. How far are we in danger of bearing false witness, of depraving the sentences of that tribunal, on which we must sit? Had we not, when we see the awful results of bearing false witness, better refrain from the judgment of others altogether and take refuge in silence? No! We must judge; we must judge decidedly of conduct—not of motive but of conduct. We must say this thing is wrong; we must condemn strongly. The world would be a worse place if we did not do so; the moral atmosphere is kept sweet and clean by such judgment. But we have no right to judge others, until we have tried to understand them. We ought to be sure of our facts; we ought to be sure we have interpreted the facts rightly. We ought not to strain words to their disadvantage, or to ascribe wrong motives, or to judge them from what they may have done when taken at a disadvantage. We ought to imitate the fairness, the demand for proof which is shown by our best judges. We might do worse, if we are disposed to judge others unfairly, than go and hear a trial and see what is accepted as evidence and what is not, and then compare the practice of the law with our own. We are sometimes angry with the law because it will not suspect or accept what “everyone knows.” Believe me, it were better to take its severe canons of evidence as our example. Mere inference from what we know about the conduct and principles of others is always dangerous. You cannot infer a

man's motives from his conduct, while to say that his principles involve odious conclusions is always to bear false witness. It might be so if it were your own case, it might be so even logically; but people are seldom logical, and to insist that they must be so is to go beyond our province. The judgment of facts, as facts, is often a duty; but it is never a duty, and often a grave danger, to infer consequences from facts; and to be sure of our facts is a first duty when we speak of others.

From this it follows that we have no right to argue from particulars to a universal. Because one man in a profession proves dishonest, we have no right to distrust the profession or to make imputations. The vileness is his own, it grows out of himself, not out of his own profession. The treachery of Judas did not make Apostleship traitorous.

2. Another thing. It is no excuse, if we bear false witness by spreading untrue reports, to say, "somebody told me." We are bound to consider whether the somebody could know the truth; whether he was the sort of person who would be likely to form a true judgment; whether we should like to be convicted on his evidence. The somebody who is a scandal monger is not a reliable person. Before you repeat a story, consider whether you have been standing in the "counsel of the ungodly," of those who go from house to house bearing false witness everywhere; whose

testimony you would wish no one to receive against yourself.

Above all, remember Christ's warning about the tongue. Life and death are in its power. We wound by the tongue not the bodies but the spirits and the hearts of men. Ah, what wonders too we work by it: we cheer the miserable, we speak words that bring hope to despair, we bind up the broken-hearted, we charm away bitter agony, we bring light to dull eyes, we raise again the fallen. Oh, wondrous power that God has given these tongues of ours to work ill or good, blessing or cursing! No wonder the Master seems to make our words our one and only probation. Let His words about the tongue sink into our hearts; let us keep them as a bridle to our lips. When we look at the terrible results of slander on ourselves and on others, let us own the love that taught us so solemnly about this terrible power of speech; let us pray that we may never forget its warning, "By thy words thou shalt be justified, and by thy words thou shalt be condemned."

SERMON XI.

SECOND SUNDAY AFTER EASTER, 1893.

“Thou shalt not covet thy neighbour’s house, thou shalt not covet thy neighbour’s wife, nor his man-servant, nor his maid-servant, nor his ox, nor his ass, nor anything that is thy neighbour’s.”—EXODUS xx. 17.

THIS is essentially even in its letter, as given to the Jews, a Commandment for the heart. It ‘tries us and seeks the ground of our heart,’ it goes behind our actions and words and finds us out as we are; we do not kill, or commit adultery, or steal, or bear false witness; but is there within us that longing to get things at the expense of others which is the essence of covetousness? It is a Commandment meant to turn men’s eyes back upon themselves as they really are, to strip off the cloak of respectability, to induce them to purify their heart. It goes straight to the real test of ultimate motive; it gets behind decency and respectability of conduct into that inner chamber, wherein the longing desire—which may or may not lead to outward sin according to circumstances—is in itself sin before God. Morally speaking, it is the deepest, the most searching of the Commandments; the one most

likely to ripen in the heart of devout and thoughtful men in old times, to awaken their sense of inability to do God's Will, to stimulate that aching sense of powerlessness, which makes a man really throw himself on God and find in Him that supernatural strength by which alone he can overcome. The battling with any external temptation is as nothing compared with the long weary inward struggle against evil desire which this Commandment, "Thou shalt not covet," stirs us up to wage—the long weary struggle not to give way inwardly, to hold one's ground, to wait upon God in the secrets of our own life, to keep the fortress and sanctuary, to preserve the heart from wishes and feelings, which it would make us blush that our nearest and dearest should know.

"It is hard," wrote one to me this week, "it is hard to form mental good habits when one is past fifty, and I must walk maimed to the end." It is harder still, even before fifty, so to possess one's heart and mind and will that one may not be conscious of a daily lameness and maimedness in the almost involuntary falls from charity and purity and unselfishness, or from honesty and truthfulness, which no one knows of, but God and ourselves.

So we see, without surprise, that it was this Commandment which found out one of the greatest spiritual heroes of Christ's kingdom, and brought him to the Crucified. Paul had kept the other

Commandments from his youth up. He had worshipped the true God, and no graven image. He had not taken God's Name in vain, nor worked on the Sabbath, nor killed, nor broken the other Commandments, but this Commandment, "Thou shalt not covet," found him out. It went behind the external blamelessness of his life and laid bare his inward evil; it convinced him of his inability to master it; it made him conscious of the war between the law in his members and the law of God. He felt himself (so he describes it), in the coils of an evil power from which he could not escape—"sold under sin;" and thus convicted, he found freedom in Christ; he learnt that in the self-sacrificing death of Christ this redemption from himself was possible. He could die with Christ and with Christ rise again. Then there grew up within his heart the antithesis to the Commandment, "Thou shalt not covet," the law of self-sacrifice, 'Thou shalt die to self'; and he obeyed it thoroughly. He checked even his desire for the rest of death because it was better for others that he should live: he wished himself 'accursed from Christ for the sake of his brethren after the flesh.' By the light of this Commandment he discovered within himself the selfishness of nature, the natural desire to get for self at the expense of others, the bad sort of individualism which wants to arrange everything for self. He became, as he tells us, "a wretched

man," until he found Him Who could and would by His infinite love redeem him from selfishness, by implanting within him the likeness of His own self-sacrificing Love.

And so this Commandment is in some respects the greatest, the most searching of all the second table. It goes straight to the root of what we all feel to be the difficulty, when we are honest about ourselves ; it puts its finger on the primary evil—selfishness. It attacks the selfish heart that longs for gratification, longs and goes on longing, even if it has to give up its own way ; that wants in some way or other to get for self, and cares nothing for the loss involved to others so long as it is gratified. It attacks the selfish instinct which is so hard to eradicate, even when good manners and cultivation cause us outwardly to appear to give up our own way ; the thing that breaks out in our own homes, that makes us cross and disagreeable, and unkind and unfair to others, when our comfort is interfered with or when we do not get what we want at once ; that makes little children feel about us that, when we come into the room, it is as though a cloud has come there, a kind of threat had got into the atmosphere, though they never express it except by the fact that their laughter is hushed and their merriment gone. Such is the depressing influence of the selfish heart that covets, that makes itself its own end ; that makes its own pleasures, its own

convenience, the one rule. It damps, depresses, devitalizes others ; it checks our own energies and takes the lightness of heart out of our joys ; it increases our sorrows and darkens our misfortunes, it is contracting, enervating, dispiriting, paralysing—it is all this and yet it is so full of self-deceit. Because we give up sometimes for the sake of decency or to avoid that wrangle which we most hate—even more than not having our own way—because we stifle its promptings to open expression and burrow underground to find roundabout ways of securing its ends, we think that we are not selfish, that we do deny ourselves. Because we do not give that dreadful open expression to the evil within, which adulterers and thieves and slanderers do, we pat ourselves on the back : we are not as those others, we do not fly in rages and stamp our feet and insist on our own way, we are carried away by no impulses into wrong acts, we have nothing to reproach ourselves with ; no voice cries to heaven against us because we have defrauded them. And yet, really all the more, the evil may be there, like a hungry watch-dog within us, waiting to spring, kept back by its chain, unmuzzled and only watching its opportunity, which any sudden surprise may bring. For every day the tendency, that goes to fix character and give tone to life, is growing secretly yet surely. Brethren, let us be honest and try to see ourselves as God sees us ; let us not say that

"we have no sin and deceive ourselves;" let us not dwell on what we give to others or what we give up or keep from, for the sake of decency; let us not be so busy, fixing imputations of selfishness on others and forgetting ourselves. The most selfish people are ready enough to see selfishness in others; but they learn nothing from the sight about themselves. Let us dig and hunt and search whether the commandment *Thou shalt not covet*—*Thou shalt not be selfish*—does not cut across our deepest feelings and our inmost desires, whether we do not still need in that way to be under the law, whether the poison of the old Adam does not lurk within us.

Nothing can cast it out but one thing—the love of Christ. "The love of Christ constraineth us because we thus judge if One died for all, then are all dead." It is of no use to groan over and bemoan our selfishness; we must be resolute about curing it, if we want to be saved. What we want is to be good within—good not because others are looking on, nor because we are ashamed of bringing out what is within us. The tree must be good before the fruit can be. What we want is to hate the desire, the longing to benefit at others' expense; we want to get another principle within us, the principle of self-sacrificing love. There is nothing else that can cure the deep decay within. All our outward actions may be fair enough; but we know what is within us, we know the direction of our secret

thoughts ; we know how little it is true to say of us that "we come not to be ministered unto but to minister ;" we know really that the truth is that we do desire to be ministered unto. The law, "Thou shalt not covet," has shown us that the desire for our own good at others' expense, *i.e.*, that selfishness is within us. Nothing can root that evil growth out but the love of Christ. And so we see that this last Commandment is a sort of link between the Old Covenant and the New. It goes behind words and deeds, and deals with desires and intentions ; it seizes the respectable man with his steady life roughly, and it says to him, "Thou shalt not covet" —thou shalt not be selfish ; it forces him to look at himself, and when he really looks he finds that these desires are there, however repressed, however latent ; he discovers himself as selfish, sold under sin, though he be so proper, so decent. "How am I to help it" he cries out, "how am I to cleanse my heart?" And thus he is brought right up to the new law as the only remedy—"Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself." But the Tenth Commandment made him ready for it, it showed him that there was no help for it ; that if evil was really to be cast out, only some positive commandment, backed by some force from heaven, could help him. And so he hears the Master's voice : "A new Commandment give I unto you that ye love one another as I have loved you ;" and he sees the Master's Cross,

and learns that redemption means not merely personal forgiveness but a new heart and a new spirit ; that salvation means not personal deliverance but soul-health—the health that only love can secure—and thus some faint likeness of the Divine Love enters in and dwells within him, and he becomes a new creature—“old things are passed away, behold all things are become new.” But the Tenth Commandment drove him to it ; the Tenth Commandment found him out—outwardly respectable, a church-goer, an honest worker, even a pure man ; but inwardly selfish—it found him out, and convinced him of sin ; it was the schoolmaster who scourged and whipped him with stings of shame, and brought him to Christ to be touched with His hand and filled with His Spirit, so that at last he lives, ‘yet not he, but Christ liveth within him,’ as a new principle, a constraining force. And then there comes a time, when he gets everything back again that he seemed at first to have lost. Desire has gone into a new key, and he finds himself no longer wishing for his neighbour’s wife, or his neighbour’s land, or his neighbour’s fortune, but wishing and desiring and longing for his neighbour’s good ; that his neighbour should be his best self and live his truest life. The old individualism, the arranging the world for his own comfort and profit has gone ; and the new Christian Socialism, the arranging the world for the good of others, as far as he can, has

come to him. Love has come into him and dwells within him, and love does make us desire the good of others. We know that it does in natural relationships. The father does not covet his son's wealth, or the mother her daughter's beauty; the brother does not look gloomy at his brother's success, but rejoices with him. We find ourselves caring more for the prosperity of others than we do for our own; it pleases us when those, whom we love, are praised far more than when we are praised ourselves, for we never covet what belongs to those whom we really love. And Christ means us to extend that more widely, to love others outside natural relationships with a love which He alone can teach us. It is His secret, His great world changing power, to teach men to love as He loves.

If I content myself with insisting on this fundamental teaching, and do not deal with the Commandment from a limited point of view—if I do not speak of covetousness or avarice in particular—it is because I know that covetousness is a sin of which no one thinks himself guilty. The covetous man calls his greed proper prudence or carefulness in money matters. Even an angel from heaven would not convince him that his love of money, which is perhaps eating out all his higher nature, is sinful. And so it seems that no one is cured of that sin alone by itself. A man may be cured of dishonesty or disobedience or even impurity, but not of covet-

ousness. For "covetousness is idolatry." If a man does love money he worships it, lives for it, and he can only be cured of that disease by the entrance of self-sacrificing love. Look at the extreme form of it in the miser. The common sense of mankind pronounces him miserable, wretched; yet he is but himself the living witness to the awful strength of this single sin to draw off the good in character, as you would drain a marsh and leave it dry and arid. Therefore let us beware of covetousness, for "a man's life consisteth not in the abundance of the things which he possesseth."

And so I bring to an end these thoughts about the Commandments. They still have their lesson to teach us. Every one of them ought to have left some mark upon us. However much the literal observance may have passed away, each one of them is charged with deep spiritual meaning. Those ten little rules, when once they are allowed to speak to the heart, when once they are taken as rules for the heart, do one great work in us—they set us free, free to worship, free to love, free to work, free to be really happy. Stern and forbidding as is their "Thou shalt not;" fatal too as any attempt at a mere literal observance of them would be, yet transfigured by our Master's Life, filled in by His teaching, they still do become instruments of noble living. They are the expressions of the moral being of God conveyed in the way in which that age could

bear it ; they are the eternal representations of what He must think and feel and be. At first they were written on stone and doubtless the hardness of that early condition clings to them still ; they require effort, struggle ; we need grace to enable us to keep them ; but one day we know they shall be written on the hearts of men.

When we see God, when we become alive to the terms of that glorious destiny before us, when we see what it is to be "partakers of the Divine Nature," we shall recognise these Commandments as faint expressions of Himself. We shall no more need definite precepts, or the offer of reward, or the fear of punishment, and yet we shall still see in the Commandments an eternal expression of the moral being of God. We shall love Him at last above all things, and so attain that perfection which needs no rule and no restraint, but which having seen the Highest straightway has no desire but to be like Him for evermore.

SERMON XII.

SEXAGESIMA, 1894.

“And, behold, one came and said unto him, Good Master, what good thing shall I do, that I may have eternal life? And he said unto him, Why callest thou me good? there is none good but One, that is, God: but if thou wilt enter into life, keep the commandments. He saith unto him, Which? Jesus said, Thou shalt do no murder, Thou shalt not commit adultery, Thou shalt not steal, Thou shalt not bear false witness, Honour thy father and thy mother: and, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself. The young man saith unto him, All these things have I kept from my youth up: what lack I yet? Jesus said unto him, If thou wilt be perfect, go and sell that thou hast, and give to the poor, and thou shalt have treasure in heaven: and come and follow, Me.”—ST MATTHEW xix. 16-21.

THE actual question put by this young ruler of the synagogue is one which would be frequently put to a Rabbi at that day by his disciples. The answer given might vary, but it would always suggest some stricter observance of the Law. “There is nothing else,” says the Talmud, “that is good, but the Law.” Instead of that Christ leads the young ruler through certain of the prohibitions of the Ten Commandments up to their one positive precept, “Honour thy father and mother,” and then to that positive and all-embracing command, “Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself”—leads him on only to find

them admitted by him as really binding, as actually kept from his youth up. His was evidently the sincere answer of an honest heart, and there is no reason to doubt either the genuineness of the efforts that he had made, or his immunity from actual outward offences against any of the commandments mentioned, or even to impute to him lack of modesty. We might well expect to find him self-satisfied with so much genuine moral achievement. But in youth there are deeper cravings, which this young man had found within him and which he could not stifle. There are higher cravings, earnest and generous, which have not yet disappeared before the paralysing influence of the world's sneers, or before indulged vicious propensities. The soul in youth longs for the true, the better, the ideal; and this great Teacher, this Rabbi as he esteemed Christ, had awakened within him at once these cravings and a vision of some possible fulfilment. Before this he had had everything which the world could give him—what we should call a great position, as far as circumstances went. He was very rich. We know what that generally means. He had a luxurious house, he gave splendid entertainments, he was the idol, as rich men always are, of a certain sort of friend. We must recognise, too, the fact that circumstances such as his undoubtedly tend to draw out the finer feelings and to give them scope. He had not yet sunk into the stupid self-sufficiency

which riches often engender later on, and which gives point to the sarcasm which often suggests itself, when we have met some plutocrat, 'that this man has money—and not much else.' Again he had nothing of Pharisaic pride, or of self-righteousness about him : he had only the self-respect which is born of conscious rectitude. But all this he felt was not enough. He had had visions and dreamed dreams, and somehow this Prophet had seemed to give them point and a possible fulfilment. His moral earnestness had brought him to the feet of One, in Whom he dimly felt there was no ordinary conventional goodness. Christ was to him no last refuge from the soul-agony of conscious guilt. He was the embodiment of his visions and the ideal of his dreams. And so, out of the vague feeling of his own personal unsatisfactoriness, in spite of his moral achievement, he blurts out the question, "What lack I yet?" And Christ saw it all and felt it all ; all the pathos of his intensity, all the ineffable sweetness of that upward look of longing, all the tragedy of disappointment that was before him ; saw, too, what he did lack—the one thing needful—saw the inward necessity, and laid His finger on the one fulfilment of that necessity. 'One thing is needful for such as thou, one thing only : companionship with Me—an absolute coming to and an entire following of Me ; and since that companionship and that following are not possible in your present mode of

life, cut yourself off from it. Since the following of One Who has not where to lay His head is obviously and plainly incompatible with great possessions, with a splendid house and grand entertainments, therefore go "sell all that thou hast and come and follow Me."

I. What I want to press upon you is that which is so often overlooked and ignored in what is written and said about this incident. The discussion so often turns on the *means* by which the young ruler was to be enabled to follow Christ, which is the accident; and not on the *following itself*, which is the essence. "Come and follow Me"—that was the answer to the question, "What lack I yet?" To follow Christ, to be His companion, to be His disciple, to learn of Him was what this man needed. All this could not be done unless he surrendered the cares and the claims of a great earthly position. The surrender of possessions was not a general condition for all who would follow Christ; but in this case it was the test as to whether he desired it enough to make him put away what obviously must interfere with it. It is clear that, immediately, he had not enough desire for it. He went back to his riches, for the time at any rate; he made what Dante calls the great refusal. Dante sees him in the number of those who are blown about like autumn leaves on the confines of the other world, blindly following a painted flag, which Heaven rejects and even

Hell despises, hateful to God and to His enemies. Among such he sees 'the shade of him who made through cowardice the great refusal.' But it seems impossible to believe that this was the issue. One cannot but follow one so obviously genuine, one so full of aspirations, in imagination, and see him come to himself and feel abashed and cut to the quick by the recollection of what might have been and what was. One sees him go back to his luxurious apartment and find that all the sweetness had gone out of life and of these conditions, which once seemed so happy; one sees him struggling to adapt himself to old ways with ever-increasing reluctance, till his possessions grow intolerable to him and he finds himself driven as it were by shame and regret and self-contempt to that life of service and companionship with Christ, which at the first had seemed not worth the price. The need, that had once awoke within him, was surely too real not to re-assert itself. That, we must not only hope, but believe, was the issue. He was the son who said at first, "I go not," but being what he was, being one whom Jesus, beholding, loved, surely "he afterwards repented and went."

We miss the real lesson if we think of the condition as universal. There is in everyone the same inward necessity, the same lacking, that there was in him. Whether we are moral or immoral, whether we keep the commandments or ignore them, there is in a greater or less degree this lack within us.

In some it seeks a refuge from the consciousness of sin ; in others it desires the fulfilment of their dreams and aspirations. There is this one lack ; and its satisfaction is in fellowship with Christ, association with Him. Deep down it may lie ; almost unknown to ourselves save by glimpses ; unperceived by others—yet there is this lack, this inward necessity. And corresponding to it, linked to it, there is some outward necessity, some forsaking which must precede the following. It may not be the forsaking of riches ; it may be the forsaking of some unholy influence, of some blighting attachment, of some too absorbing occupation, of some idle habit. It may be something positive ; an act of self-denial, a habit of prayer, a distinct saying of 'no,' an act of utter self-consecration. Be it what it may, this is the law of the Kingdom, that there is in everyone some outward necessity connected with the inward necessity : a taking up the Cross which is the condition precedent to any real discipleship of Christ. If we refuse to conform to this outward necessity, we do not rid ourselves of the inward necessity ; then it becomes our torment, the disturber of our peace, it haunts us and pursues us, it will not give us up. But there is, bound to that inward necessity, an absolutely necessary outward necessity — in some way or other we must obey the command, 'go sell all,' before we can arrive at the satisfaction of that

which is and ever must remain an inward necessity, viz., fellowship and oneness with Christ.

And this gives us the reason why morality, in itself, can never satisfy man. Morality looks hard, disagreeable, stern, unbending, ungracious, unpitiful. The Ten Commandments with their grim 'Thou shalt not,' only softened once into providing an honour for parents (which, as far as its outward sound goes, does not relieve the general chill which the sense of their sternness gives)—the Ten Commandments do not give us what answers to this inward necessity. We still want to know why we should sacrifice "I like" to "I ought." Only in Christ does the moral law find both its interpretation and the motive for obedience to it. Christ became man to show us at once the beauty of the perfect life and the means of its attainment. To be one with Him, to share in mystical communion His Life—not only to admire, to long for Him, but to know Him and the power of His Resurrection within us, to rise to His ideals and to be His very own—that is the only satisfaction of this inward necessity. To obey the moral law, even to keep the commandments, does not satisfy ; the lacking goes on. But become at one with Him, live His Life as he did who cried in one exhaustive sentence 'To me to live is Christ,' and the inward necessity is realised. Whatever is involved in this, even the selling all that we have, becomes possible directly

the inward necessity is realised. 'Those things which were gain to me I counted them as dung that I might win Christ and be found in Him,' cries St Paul, not for the satisfaction of a mere selfish egotism, or a mere desire to find peace, or to secure himself from possible loss, but from the deepest conviction that there and there alone with Christ and in Christ could be found his true life, the life he was meant to live, the full life which alone could bless others. No bare morality, no keeping of an external law could sustain this life; nothing could but perfect association with Christ, nothing could but oneness with Him.

II. And here we reach a point at which we come into collision with some modern tendencies. Broadly speaking, the question of the hour is, "Can we dispense with Christ?" Has He taught us all He can teach? Have we exhausted the depth of His sayings and come to the end of His direct influence? Can civilisation now step in and with the aid of Christian morality (which everyone desires to perpetuate), educate and refine man here, and give him some view of life which shall be at any rate intelligible? There is something very attractive in the theory that you can take all the results of Christian teaching and Christian influence and apply them to the refining, the civilising, and the educating of the world, and leave behind all the old questions of theology and doctrine, which have

so divided men, and which have often made them hard and narrow and bitter and petty and cramped and ungenerous. To those who care about the present wellbeing of man, who are not contented with the present lot of the great majority, who see in all the widening and developing of man's life by education, by emancipation from unwholesome conditions, the results of the Incarnation of the Son of God—to those who see in this present hour the sure, though gradual, extension of the true idea of Christ's empire over the souls and bodies of men—to these the attraction of such a theory is indisputable. The narrowness of many Christians; the pettiness of the ecclesiastical point of view; the class selfishness which seems its natural ally; the respectable Pharisaism which will not touch real wants and needs with the hem of its garment; but keeps on mouthing its stale formulas in every Church assembly; the cruelty of its attitude in mingling patronage which degrades with the injustice which hurts—all this repels and is calculated to upset the moral balance of generous souls, to make them inclined to think whether you cannot build up Christian morality without troubling about the truth of the Incarnation; whether you cannot sacrifice the roots and yet preserve the flower.

How shall we meet this mood which is the danger of not a few high and noble souls around

us? Shall we meet it with the old Church policy of anathema, of imputation, of misrepresentation, of hurling threats of damnation? God forbid! Shall we not rather speak to it thus—‘In everything that you can say about the necessity of progress, of education, of elevating institutions, of giving people the power to regulate their own lives, we are at one with you. We believe that society is meant to be always improving, we believe in the development of the powers of every human being, we believe all such ends must be followed with deep and earnest devotion for their own sake. But we believe in this because the Son of God became Man, and out of that stupendous fact come other thoughts about life, which alone can make these developments sure and lasting.’

We do not believe in education, civilisation, or refinement raising men permanently apart from Christ. At the end of all modern versions of the Ten Commandments which may be promulgated by philosophy, morality, or science, we believe that the question would remain, “What lack I yet?” The severe requirements of the New Testament come in here, not to mock, not to insult, not to discourage but to regulate; to give us the true measure of things here, to give us the compensation for their failure and the hope of completion for their imperfection. Otherwise the vision of a completely civilised educated world

that has (as far as devotion goes) parted with Christ, or only left Him a niche in its pantheon, along with Socrates and Shakespeare and Marcus Aurelius, is a dream—a dream from which the awakening will be only too bitter.

That same wondrous and prophetic imagination which has taught us in this place so many lessons, has given us in the poem *Cleon* a picture in broad outlines and distinct colours of the despair of civilisation. In that poem he pictures man perfectly civilised having left the lower and unconscious forms of life and grown to the only life, the life of culture, the pleasure house.

* Watch tower and treasure fortress of the soul,
Which whole surrounding flats of natural life
Seemed only fit to yield subsistence to ;
A tower that crowns the country.

It is a magnificent conception of the educated, refined, civilised man. And then comes the awful awakening to its utter unsatisfactoriness.

But alas,
The soul now climbs it just to perish there !

And then he pictures the visions from that tower of capacity for joy, spread round it, meant for it mocking it, and the agony of the soul finding itself less capable of enjoyment even than before. The very fatigue consequent on the realisation has brought destruction to it.

* Browning's Poems, Vol. v. p. 307.

. . . We struggle, fain to enlarge
 Our bounded physical reciprocity,
 Increase our power, supply fresh oil to life
 Repair the waste of age and sickness : no,
 It skills not, life's inadequate to joy.

Most progress is most failure :

He fails just as he is learning the value of gifts
 which he longs to use and cannot. To his patron
 Protus he writes :—

. . . Thou diest while I survive ?
 Say rather that my fate is deadlier still,
 In this, that every day my sense of joy
 Grows more acute, my soul (intensified
 By power and thought) more enlarged, more keen ;
 While every day my hairs fall more and more,
 My hand shakes, and the heavy years increase—
 The horror quickening still from year to year,
 The consummation coming past escape,
 When I shall know most, and yet least enjoy.

The progress of culture without the spiritual
 outlet which communion with Christ brings, with-
 out the vision of the Eternal, beyond time and
 sense, being one with us, is only more and more
 unsatisfying. When we have kept all the com-
 mandments of science and philosophy and civilisa-
 tion, the question will recur, "What lack I yet?"
 The inward necessity repeats itself.

We speak sometimes as if it were only poverty
 and wretchedness and failure that made men
 hungry for the Eternal, for the Divine, but the
 sense of imperfection which haunts our highest

success is really a more powerful agent than any adversity. We find our inevitable limitations in the most brilliant successes, and they convince us of that inward necessity which has but one meaning and can find only one satisfaction.

“Lord, Thou hast made us for Thee and the heart is restless till it rest in Thee.” The need endures and will endure even with the consciousness of a clean well ordered life. “One thing thou lackest,” — one thing, at the end of all achievement, more truly even than at the beginning—to see, to know, to follow, to be one with the Eternal Christ.

